DEBATER GUIDE TO
RELATIONSHIPS

Improve romantic partnerships, friendships, and parent-child relationships

16Personalities

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Introduction

Why Relationships Matter to Debaters

Debaters don't always have an accurate sense of their audience or what their audience wants, and their sympathy and empathy sometimes fall short of others' expectations. But it would be an incomplete picture to define their relationships by those challenges. Debaters can be stimulating companions and usually have a fresh spin on any topic of conversation. Despite occasionally reacting inappropriately toward other people, they often generously aid those in need and offer practical support to others. As Extraverts, they interact with the world energetically, and their impact reverberates through their social and personal lives.

Their sometimes blunt way of expressing themselves can give Debaters a hard, insensitive appearance. Other personality types either find them quirky, exciting, and attractive or feel uncomfortable and become offended. And although Debaters may not necessarily want to alienate others, they aren't always aware of their tendency to do so. The people who overcome Debaters' initial roughness find a steadfast spirit underneath.

Debaters' style may not be for those who prefer the conventional, particularly those who stay faithful to their fixed ideas. Although Debaters need to be part of society, conforming to please others is not high on their list of priorities. This may lead them to passionately argue their unique positions to people who don't want to discuss conflicting and maybe even threatening arguments against their own beliefs. It can become a game for Debaters, who might convince themselves that everybody wants to hash out difficult and complex ideas. For most people who aren't Debaters, though, argument as recreation quickly wears thin. For these personality types, improving their ability to "read the room" and making tactful decisions about how they express themselves – while still doing so – is part of their social development.

The Joy of Give-and-Take

If Debaters are sometimes tone-deaf in their pursuit of social interactions with others, it's often because they find such interplay mentally and emotionally stimulating and get carried away. For these personality types, argument may contain elements of humor, facetiousness, and exploration as well as pointed opinions. Debaters

don't necessarily seek to subdue others, though. They enjoy when people launch worthy facts and opinions at them as if returning a shot in a game of mental tennis. A back-and-forth exchange brings Debaters joy, especially if it's energetic. For people with this personality type, forming and maintaining great relationships doesn't mean hiding their love of spirited exchanges – it just means working to ensure that all parties involved in an interaction can share in the same joy.

To be fulfilling, social relationships must give each participant enough of what they need to be happy. It's right and healthy for Debaters to seek out people who can handle their bold style, just as it's appropriate for them to also take care regarding how they make others feel. Debaters tend to have strong, durable minds, and they can adapt to many different social styles and settings when they're given good reason to do so. The way that Debaters enjoy provoking others has more than one facet, and when they feel close to someone, they can just as easily turn their wit and verbal nimbleness to eliciting laughter as they can to sparring. And perhaps most importantly, they find that kind of exchange just as personally satisfying. It's in Debaters' nature to seek out or create vibrant interactions, and social relationships offer some of the most rewarding opportunities to do so. Of course, as is the case with most forms of give-and-take, what Debaters receive often depends on what they offer.

Want to boost your understanding of the traits that make up your personality type and the theory behind them? Learn more here.

Romantic Relationships

Debaters spice up their romantic relationships just as they add flavor to other areas of their lives: by entertaining new perspectives and indulging in contrarian views. Their cognitive flexibility enables them to enjoy the company of partners who are radically different from themselves – and given Debaters' relatively unique perspective and their rarity as a type, that means nearly everyone. Their critical thinking skills can be surprisingly useful in romantic contexts. Thanks to their combination of rationality and open-mindedness, Debaters have a solid foundation when it comes to making important decisions in tandem with their significant others.

All that said, people with this personality type often need to moderate their argumentative tendencies with romantic partners. However well intended, a barrage of debates and disagreements can come across as nitpicking, engendering resentment or hurt feelings among their loved ones. Debaters must learn to operate from the assumption that they're on the same team as their partners, while still maintaining their curiosity about different points of view. It may take time and effort to achieve such balance. Fortunately, Debaters aren't afraid of a worthy challenge, and love can provide all the motivation they need.

Surprisingly Passionate

It's easy to assume that all individuals with the Thinking trait – including Debaters – are unromantic or unfeeling, yet anyone who's seen Debaters in heated intellectual arguments can attest to their passion. But can that passion translate to romantic relationships? Of course. As

Extraverts, Debaters draw energy from spending time with others, and this proves true in matters of the heart as well as the mind.

People with this personality type crave connection as much as anyone, and their inner spark helps them stand out as enthusiastic, captivating, passionate lovers. Compared with most other Analysts, novelty and change stimulate Debaters, and they use that preference to stoke the fires of their relationships. They want to shake up the status quo on a regular basis. The result is that their relationships rarely settle into the stale ruts or tired routines that eventually weigh down many long-term partnerships.

Love Lockdown

However strong their feelings may be, Debaters don't stand out as emotionally expressive. In many cases, they don't see the utility of overtly expressing affection – at least not in conventionally romantic ways. As far as they're concerned, the mere fact that they've devoted time and energy to a relationship should be proof enough of their love. Socially sanctioned expressions of affection – from Valentine's flowers to elaborate proposals – can seem trite or hollow to Debaters, who regard many social norms with a critical eye. When they do go along with such conventions, it's often a calculated maneuver to please their partners rather than a spontaneous outpouring of emotion. But as their relationships mature, Debaters often learn to express their feelings – including love and affection – more readily and authentically.

Alas, Debaters' reluctance to express emotion runs deeper than social contrarianism. Emotionally blocked Debaters tend to resent situations that make them "lose control" of their emotions, and in the context of romantic relationships, they may inadvertently take out that resentment on their significant others. Although it's perfectly natural to experience intense feelings, many Debaters conflate the experience with abandoning rationality or losing control. Unless they learn to share their emotions in healthy ways – *and* share in their partners' expressions of emotion – Debaters will struggle to build egalitarian relationships that can withstand conflict while allowing for exuberance, joy, and true connection.

Daters Gonna Date

As Analysts, Debaters don't always appreciate the superficial niceties of dating rituals. Whether they're wondering when to text someone they've met or who should pay for dinner, people with this personality type often take issue with the social conventions of courtship. But rituals often have a distinct purpose, however irrational they might seem. Debaters who throw convention to the wind sometimes discourage potential partners unintentionally – they may get better results if they at least respect dating rituals, even if they don't always play by the rules.

Other pitfalls can cause Debaters to stumble early in relationships. Small talk, the stuff of first dates, baffles them. They'd rather dive deep, exploring controversial issues. At times, they might embark on lengthy monologues about subjects they find fascinating, particularly if it gives them the opportunity to show off an unusual stance or opinion. That approach, however well intended, can come across to other types as aggressive, critical, or tone-deaf. Debaters might walk away from a date thinking they've shared a fantastic, lively conversation, but the other person may complain afterward to a friend, "My date wouldn't let me get a word in edgewise."

That phenomenon can reappear through all stages of their relationships. Debaters' confidence is tied to their ability to put together a winning argument, and when their self-esteem is challenged, they may overcompensate by showing off their analytical prowess. Unfortunately, a brash, cerebral demonstration, especially a showy one, may come across as arrogant or excessive to their dates – and anyone else within earshot. Ironically, Debaters may win people over more easily when they don't try too hard.

People with this personality type can see past superficial traits like physical attractiveness and social status to identify partners who are truly good matches for them. They can spot potential in others, even people quite dissimilar to them, and willingly imagine how a relationship with any given person might play out. Though such predictions don't always hold true, Debaters' incisiveness can save them years of chasing after individuals who aren't a match for them. When they do find someone they like, Debaters favor a charismatic blend of boldness and authenticity to capture the attention of potential lovers.

Keeping the Love Alive – Or Not

Even if they seem stoic or unruffled on the outside, Debaters don't escape pain when their romances struggle – which all relationships do, at one point or another. Those with a balanced, positive approach to their relationships pause to evaluate the situation, using their natural tendency toward open-mindedness to consider what's working and what isn't. They also engage their partners candidly but sensitively, taking care to listen as much as they talk. Using the resulting insights, balanced Debaters work with their significant others to develop a concrete plan to improve their relationships. Above all, they ensure that they give the connection a fair chance before giving up on it.

Debaters with an imbalanced approach might dissect the situation in unhelpful, blame-oriented ways, focusing on their lovers' shortcomings. Alternatively, they might overreact to misalignments in their relationships, perhaps even initiating breakups right away to avoid future messiness and painful emotions. Again, this tends to stem from a desire to protect themselves. Unfortunately, a "shoot first, ask questions later" attitude comes at the expense of true intimacy.

Once Debaters discover that there's more to life than being right, they're more likely to experience love and romance. It may be hard for them to fully experience the intimacy of love. But if they allow themselves to expand their comfort zones, work on their emotional intelligence, and let other people into their world, Debaters will find a new dimension of life. The act of connecting to a trusted partner on emotionally and physically intimate levels leads Debaters to tremendous personal growth. When lovers reveal those facets of life to them, Debaters give the gifts of loyalty and imaginative insight in exchange.

Potential Pairings

Cultivating lasting relationships isn't always easy, especially for a personality type that so restlessly questions the status quo. Whether in romantic partnerships or other aspects of their lives, Debaters won't settle for something "good enough." As a result, they aren't content with partnerships that, however comfortable or convenient, remain superficial. Fortunately, every personality type has something to contribute, and as Debaters date and pursue long-term romances, they find many opportunities for meaningful connections.

The following sections explain common patterns in relationships between Debaters and each of the different Role groups – Analysts, Diplomats, Sentinels, and Explorers. By understanding the patterns, people with the Debater personality type can approach their romantic lives with insight and strategic awareness, maximizing their chances of finding and sustaining meaningful, loving partnerships.

Debater-Analyst Relationships

It's often said that "opposites attract," as if human hearts were emotional magnets. If that's true, it's fortunate that no two people are exactly alike, even if they share the same basic personality traits, like Debaters and other Analysts. Although their shared Intuitive and Thinking traits lend similarities, different Energy and Tactics aspects also influence each partner's personality, as well as the impact of personal experiences and life lessons. Even with their similarities, these lovers have plenty of nuances and differences to keep their relationships exciting.

Balanced Debater-Analyst Relationships

Expanding Comfort Zones Together

Debaters and their Analyst partners can connect deeply over stimulating conversations, common interests, and their shared intellectual drive. Their dinners together are short on small talk and simple accounts of each other's days. Instead, they might swap big ideas, share clever insights, and dissect hypothetical scenarios. In fact, such couples may regard their interactions as a refuge from the petty world they must put up with outside of their romance.

These couples grow together if they take a balanced approach to their relationships, not only enjoying their shared affinities but also working together to expand their comfort zones. Ironically, for these couples, venturing beyond their comfort zones may entail taking it easy – for example, relaxing or indulging in simple pleasures. Even Analysts need light and spontaneous fun occasionally. Reminding each other of that, through word or action, lightens some of the heaviness of expectations and responsibility.

Above the Shoulders

When any two Analyst types bond romantically, they favor intellectual rather than emotional stimulation. This might seem to indicate a complete absence of spark or passion, but that's not at all true. These couples communicate their passion most readily by sharing ideas and insights rather than by delving into emotional terrain. The dynamic can be perfectly healthy, if both partners recognize such conversations as expressions of mutual esteem and affection.

These couples appreciate frank discussion, which – in balanced relationships – enables them to deal with sticking points in a timely manner. Debaters in healthy partnerships with other Analysts face their issues head-on. They discuss areas of conflict in clear, precise terms, always keeping an eye toward solutions. Provided they see each other as being on the same side, they can find satisfaction and improve their relationships by working together to understand their issues – then solve them.

Unbalanced Debater-Analyst Relationships

Subconscious Expectations

If reliance on reason comes at the expense of understanding, Debaters and their Analyst partners may think their love needs underlying rationales or reasons, rather than accepting that their feelings exist outside of their conscious understanding or control. As a way of hunting for such rationales, Debaters and other Analysts may assess and measure their lovers. Because their expectations tend to be quite lofty, any partners or potential partners, in time, will fall short.

Debaters might feel they know exactly what they need in a romantic relationship. For example, they might believe they would do best with someone exactly like themselves and therefore pursue fellow Analysts. However, that line of thinking has a few logical problems. First, no one can know exactly what sort of romantic partner is best for them. Second, even the most comprehensive checklist can't capture the full complexity of a specific person. Unaccounted-for dimensions of complexity can make all the difference between a successful partnership and an unsuccessful one. Third, Analysts are a diverse group of people, with varying traits and different life experiences. Debaters must recognize their partners (and potential partners) as unique individuals. If they can't set aside their checklists and expectations, they can expect unhappiness, tension, and disconnection, rather than romantic bliss.

Organizational Meltdowns

Organization can be problematic for Debaters and their Analyst partners. Both are Intuitive – they prefer to think about novel, big-picture ideas, as well as the future. But between the two of them, who puts dinner on the table every night? Who buys the groceries? When visionary types come together, practical matters frequently suffer. As much as they may like the idea of an organized home, the reality of conquering the mundane chores may not be quite as attractive. The issue might never come up during the dating phase, but it can cause tension once they move in together.

Decision-making can also pose problems for these couples, particularly when they must choose from many imperfect or uncertain options. It's easy to imagine harried Debater-Analyst couples spending countless evenings researching, brainstorming, and pacing back and forth in their dining rooms. They may discuss and argue for and against a decision for hours without coming to a final decision. This phenomenon isn't exclusive to major life decisions, either: A Saturday trip to a park can become a joyless affair if these couples can't relax, set aside their checklists, and step out into the world.

Rebalancing Debater-Analyst Relationships

Communicating Appreciation

Even the most rational people have flaws. Debater-Analyst couples may want to experiment with getting out of their heads occasionally and living in the here and now. Appreciating each other instead of analyzing can strengthen their loving relationships. People are tremendously complex, and even the most astute Debaters may never fully understand everything about their beloveds. But this is a feature, not a bug. The strength of these romances comes when both people enjoy their partners as they are – not try to impose their preconceptions on each other.

Debaters and other Analysts may not be fluent in the language of the heart, but that doesn't mean they shouldn't attempt to talk about their feelings – including their appreciation for their lovers. Any relationship can suffer if partners fail to share what they admire about each other. Debaters can take a more proactive stance by doing the following:

- Grab a piece of a paper and write at the top, "*I feel loved when my partner*..." List specific actions that trigger feelings of being loved, respected, and understood.
- During the list-making process, pay attention to other emotions that arise, such as happiness, contentment, peace, love, joy, warmth, or gratefulness. List the emotions next to each entry that elicits them.
- The next time your partner does one of the things on the list, comment on how you feel and express appreciation. For example, "I feel grateful when you make coffee for me in the morning. Thank you."

The goal is for Debaters to notice and express gratitude for the everyday things they appreciate about their partners, which can be a powerful antidote for preconceptions and expectations. By demonstrating how to communicate emotions, Debaters can break open their relationships with Analysts, creating an environment where both partners feel secure sharing how they feel.

The Dreaded Chore Chart

Practically speaking, it is wise for Debater-Analyst couples to address chores and responsibilities head-on. If they ignore everyday to-dos, they will find themselves mired in unnecessary stress, which inevitably takes its toll on romance. Something as trivial as having nothing to cook for dinner can trigger an argument at the end of a long day.

Fortunately, these couples don't have to spend all their free time on chores – nor should they. Instead, they can create calendar reminders for recurring tasks such as picking up groceries or dry cleaning, as well as establish automatic bill payments. They also can consider outsourcing certain tasks such as maintaining the lawn and cleaning the house, if resources permit.

These lovers also may want to avoid taking on too many projects or products that require routine maintenance, from "fixer-upper" houses to additional cars – unless they truly love such things, that is. Keeping their material world simple is the name of the game. By minimizing the number of claims on their time and attention, they can free up time to learn and grow together. To accomplish this, they can try the following exercise:

- Set aside 30 minutes to discuss household responsibilities. Program a half-hour into a timer or alarm clock – and be sure to finish the exercise before it goes off.
- Discuss each partner's vision for a well-run, well-maintained life. How clean does the home have to be? How often must laundry be done?
- List every recurring chore, sorting them into the following categories: finances, cleaning and laundry, home maintenance, shopping and errands, and miscellaneous. If relevant, add child care, yard maintenance, car maintenance, and any other responsibilities specific to your lifestyles.
- Circle every item that can be automated, such as paying bills or setting aside a certain amount of money from each paycheck for retirement. Decide which partner will set up the automations and mutually determine a deadline for doing so. If possible, tackle such tasks in the moment, while the inspiration to do so is fresh.

- Cross out sources of "chore stress" that can be eliminated, such as underused tools, unworn clothes, or unloved clutter that just fills up the cabinets and accumulates dust. Plan how to dispose of the items appropriately.
- Divide the remaining tasks, mutually agreeing on who will take care of what and how frequently they will do so. Set aside some chores to do together, and find ways to make them relatively enjoyable – such as putting on music or pairing a trip to the hardware store with a visit to a pizza parlor.
- Every week, revisit the list and decide which tasks will be prioritized for the days ahead. Schedule time to take care of them.

This simple 30-minute process can reduce chore-related stress and help couples create systems for tackling practical responsibilities. The result: more time to enjoy each other's company and fewer distractions as they work toward their missions.

Debater-Diplomat Relationships

Comfortable with ideas and abstractions, Debaters and Diplomats share a visionary, open-minded view of the world. Despite their mutual interest in creativity and inspiration, however, they aren't identical – in romance, each offers capabilities that don't come naturally to the other. Whereas Debaters excel at improving systems and assessing lines of thinking, Diplomats enjoy profound human insight. As time progresses, their differing perspectives can enable Debater-Diplomat couples to balance each other's weaknesses and bring out the best in each other, creating loving bonds of mutual respect and trust.

Balanced Debater-Diplomat Relationships

Embracing Thoughtfulness

Like Debaters, Diplomats are attracted to bold, original thinking. Neither has much patience for small talk – their romantic connection thrives when they get past formalities. Some might say, "We don't discuss religion or politics at the dinner table," but these Intuitive types might both respond, "Then what's there to talk about?" Diplomats delve into the human side of issues, and Debaters push for thorough, logical understanding. When they value their differing perspectives as complementary rather than incompatible, the result is lively, meaningful conversation – and lasting attraction.

Given their creative, imaginative minds, these lovers find endless subjects to discuss. Topics that combine technology and human progress – using social media to apply pressure to oppressive regimes or corrupt institutions, for example – can have them talking for months, as can more personal discussions about goals and dreams. Far from idle chit-chat, their conversations reignite the spark, fostering respect, affection, and mutual curiosity even as the relationship progresses.

A Balanced Team

Debaters often struggle to bring warmth and emotion into their relationships, and Diplomats balance that out beautifully. Leading by example, Diplomats can help Debaters better understand not just sensitivity and romance, but also the value of human connections that transcend the realm of intellectual respect. They also may inspire Debaters to recognize the value of being altruistic and prioritizing others. With Diplomats' help, Debaters can reap the rewards of an emotional attunement that surpasses intellect alone.

In turn, Debaters often impress their Diplomat significant others through their ability to wrangle with big ideas in rational ways. In healthy relationships, Debaters offer reasoned, thoughtful stances on difficult, complex decisions – from which house to buy to the merits of a different political view. They also remind Diplomats to be realistic when it comes to committing their time and energy to helping others. Unlike some other types, Debaters can offer reason without curtailing

these couples' shared sense of progress and possibility. The result is a beautiful counterpoint to Diplomats' idealistic – and at times unrealistic – fervor.

Unbalanced Debater-Diplomat Relationships

Emotionally Unprepared

Debaters' idealization of rationality and pragmatism can chafe against Diplomats' emotional attunement. It can become especially prominent when Diplomats want to release pent-up emotion by venting about their problems to their lovers. In such situations, rather than express sympathy or compassion, Debaters typically jump in to offer solutions. They might even take a devil's advocate approach, trying to talk Diplomats out of their negative emotions.

In many cases, that backfires, making Diplomat partners feel invalidated and unheard. Diplomats may misinterpret Debaters' suggestions and advice as a cold lack of empathy, perhaps even a lack of caring. When Diplomats talk about their problems, they often want their loved ones to listen to them and acknowledge their pain, not to "correct" their thinking or offer an action plan.

The dynamic works in both directions. Diplomat partners may instinctively offer empathy to Debaters, who are often looking for rational solutions rather than "touchy-feely" sentiments. Debaters may be bewildered by Diplomats' willingness to engage directly with emotions in conversation. Diplomats are willing to say, "Are you feeling OK?" or "You seem down. What's going on?" Although they believe they're offering warmth and compassion, such inquiries are sometimes heard differently by Debaters, who may perceive such directness as overly dramatic or emotionally provocative. Diplomats, in turn, may feel dejected when their Debater lovers don't seem to understand their good intentions, whereas Debaters may remain frustrated by unwanted injections of emotionality into their problems. As a result, both can miss out on the intimate understanding that's one of the most remarkable aspects of romantic relationships.

Different Concepts of Romance

Debaters and Diplomats think differently when it comes to romantic gestures and emotional expression. Diplomats enjoy hearing words of affirmation and sharing affectionate touch with their significant others as indicators of love, and they may feel neglected when their partners don't express their love in emotional ways. Debaters, however, may prefer to express their romantic feelings in more practical or rational ways – for example, by offering guidance or simply being present. However, Diplomats might not understand such actions as indicators of affection, craving more emotional expressions of love instead.

During the dating stage, Debaters might successfully "fake" some of the sentimental rituals of courtship. Soon enough, however, Diplomats detect when a gesture doesn't come from the heart. In such a circumstance, they may feel disappointed, much to Debaters' chagrin – when Debaters perform romantic gestures, they do it solely to make their partners happy; if they've gone through the motions of buying flowers or writing a lovey-dovey message in a greeting card, they expect their beloveds to feel pleased, not disappointed. The gap might seem like a superficial obstacle, but demonstrations of emotional support and connection mean a great deal to Diplomats – something Debaters may struggle to understand.

Rebalancing Debater-Diplomat Relationships

Focusing on Understanding

When Diplomat partners come to them with a complaint or a problem, Debaters might be tempted to offer guidance, advice, and ideas for solutions. If Diplomats are hoping for support and validation rather than feedback, however, a significant disconnect can arise. The consequence is that neither feels valued or understood; as a result, they lose out on the opportunity to truly understand each other.

In such conversations, Debaters can suppress the instinct to suggest a solution immediately, starting instead with a validating statement – for example, "That really does sound difficult." By engaging in active listening rather than leaping in with advice, Debaters can help their Diplomat lovers feel heard and understood. At some point, once

Diplomats have had an opportunity to share their feelings, it may be appropriate for Debaters to ask whether they want some suggestions. However, they should actively resist offering any advice until they receive the go-ahead. Here's how Debaters can effectively listen:

- Eliminate all distractions – power down the cell phones, close the laptops, and turn off the television.
- Invite your Diplomat partner to speak their piece.
- Participate in the conversation with clarifying questions: "When you say 'X,' what do you mean?"
- Don't try to "correct" or minimize how your Diplomat partner is feeling. Instead, express validation by acknowledging their emotions.
- While listening, refrain from attempts to "solve" the problem, whether internally or aloud. All attention should be focused on listening, understanding, and validating.
- Check any interpretations by saying, "What I'm hearing you say is that you feel *[feeling]* because *[trigger or activating event*]. Is that right?"
- When tempted to offer a solution, ask, "Would you like me to offer support, or are you looking for solutions?" This not only allows your partner to clearly state their needs but also reminds them that you are ready to offer practical advice if it's needed.
- If the summary is correct, take some time to think about a response. If the situation calls for it, ask what steps could be taken together as a couple to remedy the situation.

A well-known saying goes, "Do you want to be right, or do you want to be loved?" Debaters might roll their eyes at this line of thinking, but the truth is that they sometimes need to temper the need to prove themselves right (or prove others wrong) to foster healthy romance. Although diplomacy may not be Debaters' most natural tendency (statistically, they much prefer "negotiation"), it can be learned. Being more of a small "d" diplomat can be helpful in creating bonds, especially with capital "D" Diplomats.

Sharing Love Effectively

Relationship expert Gary Chapman theorizes that people feel and express love in five ways: words of affirmation, quality time, acts of service, physical touch, and gifts. Different people prefer different modes of expressing love, which Chapman refers to as "love languages." Unless partners share their love in ways that their beloveds understand and feel, couples can become increasingly isolated and resentful.

What does this mean for Debater-Diplomat couples? In many cases, Debaters must recognize that their Diplomat partners' love languages – which might include words of affirmation, physical touch, and gifts – are just as valid as the love languages that seem more rational, such as acts of service or quality time. In that light, Debaters can work to understand what makes their significant others feel loved and respected, and – just as importantly – they can learn to take joy in doing whatever elicits positive feelings. With time, Debaters might find that expressions of love that used to seem frivolous or pointless, such as buying a birthday card and writing a personalized message in it, become pleasurable because they bring so much happiness to their Diplomat lovers.

Here's how Debaters can effectively express love to their Diplomat partners:

- Investigate how your partner expresses love. What gestures do they use? Do they say kind things, offer foot massages, give gifts, help with pesky chores, or plan quality time together? Chances are that their actions reflect their preferences for how they'd like to receive affection.
- Keep a running list of such gestures, perhaps in a notebook or a mobile device.
- Reciprocate affection daily by offering one of the gestures to your Diplomat lover. Using your powerful intuition, you can deduce what your partner could use in the moment, and you can harness your natural spontaneity to act right away.

By learning how to share their love in ways their Diplomat partners can feel, Debaters can focus their energy and attention on gestures of affection that truly make a difference in their relationships.

Debater-Sentinel Relationships

What happens when those who are fascinated by disruptive ideas fall in love with those who value stability? Debaters and Sentinels might not seem like an easy match, but they have much to offer each other. Debaters are often amazed by Sentinels' resilient effectiveness, and Sentinels who long to break out of their shells may fall in love with the way Debaters open themselves to new experiences and new ways of thinking. In these romances, Sentinels' persistence and pragmatism can inspire Debaters to deliver on their big ideas, and in return, Debaters can help Sentinels throw off the weight of social expectations and needless obligations.

Balanced Debater-Sentinel Relationships

Clear Desires

Even in the dating phase, Debaters' and Sentinels' shared interest in effectiveness can help them find common ground. In general, Debaters hold rationally developed expectations for what they'd like to find in potential mates. Sentinels' requirements tend to be different, gleaned from their upbringing, their life experiences, and societal expectations. That said, both recognize that the other has strong opinions as to what they want, and for them, few traits are more seductive than that kind of clarity.

If they allow *some* room for the illogic of love, these couples can easily recognize how their strengths complement each other. Debaters' no-nonsense analytical skills can appeal to Sentinels' desire for a partner who offers a well-reasoned life. In turn, Sentinels may appeal to Debaters through their organizational abilities, their attention to detail,

and their acuity when it comes to community building – three areas where Debaters may at times feel inadequate. Provided their life goals are aligned, these lovers have what it takes to articulate their desires and work together to achieve them – *and* find the process surprisingly enjoyable.

Never a Dull Moment (Seriously)

When we think of exciting personality types, Sentinels might not be the first to come to mind. But in relationships, Debaters and Sentinels can provide each other with just enough novelty to keep things spicy. Debaters bring an influx of new ideas to romance, keeping Sentinels from settling into ruts and drudgery. Sentinels may roll their eyes at many of the things their Debater partners say and do, but if their relationships have a solid foundation of respect, Debaters might find this pushback a turn-on rather than a deal-breaker.

Over time, Debater-Sentinel couples turn new ideas into lasting traditions together – a blend that satisfies both. For example, if these lovers talk about news stories over breakfast every morning, Debaters can delight in engaging with fresh perspectives and information with their partners, whereas Sentinels can enjoy the stability of a shared routine. This might not sound like much fun to other personality types, but for these two, it's the stuff of lasting connection.

Unbalanced Debater-Sentinel Relationships

Misalignments

If Debaters dismiss the things their Sentinel partners enjoy as "boring" or "staid," they risk feeling bored in their romances. Debaters enjoy constant stimulation, but Sentinels crave predictability, often returning to the same routines and activities. Something as seemingly trivial as arguing over whether to try a hip new place for dinner or return to an old standby can cause real tension for these couples, leading Debaters to feel stifled and Sentinels to feel judged or misunderstood.

Debaters who don't cultivate an open mind might assume that their Sentinel partners' hobbies or preferences are boring, without even trying them. Sentinels' interests might not be as edgy as Debaters', and

Sentinels may even enjoy staying home on a more regular basis than their Debater significant others. Debaters may not share their loved ones' interests, but if they allow this to erode their respect for their partners, they will put the relationship at risk.

Taken for Granted

Clashing over practical matters can be a regular occurrence when Intuitive and Observant types spend time together. Debaters can appear absent-minded – or mentally overstimulated – in the light of Sentinels' concrete pragmatism. Debaters might like the *idea* of organization and planning, but Sentinels live it. Conflict comes when Debaters don't marry their idealized version of planning with reality. Such organization is the core of Sentinels' very being and grounds them, but Debaters may shrug it off as "not *that* important."

Debaters might fail to value the practical, small-scale contributions their Sentinel partners make to their shared lives. Taking out the trash, paying the bills, or even booking restaurant reservations might seem like trivial or even unnecessary affairs to Debaters, but the actions take work and are integral to a smoothly functioning relationship. Like anyone, Sentinels enjoy being valued, and when gratitude isn't forthcoming, they may veer into passive-aggressive terrain. This triggers vague, hard-to-pin-down tension in their romance; consequently, Debaters might not even realize that their lovers feel disrespected or taken for granted.

Rebalancing Debater-Sentinel Relationships

Heal Thyself

A common mistake between romantic partners is to see one's own traits as superior to those of the other person. Attempting to remake a significant other into one's own image is rarely successful. Debaters need to appreciate that Sentinels won't always be comfortable with their big ideas and their constant attempts to reimagine things. Without such awareness, trying to force Sentinels to "get it" can become a futile obsession.

However, before Debaters criticize their partners (or even indulge in internalized judgment), they can take a hard look at whether they even meet their own standards of broadmindedness. Have they opened themselves to the unfamiliar ideas and approaches their beloveds have embraced, such as setting weekly routines or joining a civic group?

For an exercise, Debaters can try "going along for the ride":

- Participate in something your Sentinel partner enjoys (e.g., a television show, the tennis club, drinks with friends).
- Actively seek out the good in each activity and determine whether the reality of each situation matches your preconceived expectations.
- Gather empirical evidence with the intent of observation, not to prove something wrong.
- Use what you've observed to suggest new activities that satisfy your partner's preferences. This will give your lover a familiar base, even as you push into new territory.

With a few steps and the right attitude, the differences between these two can be the spice that makes their romantic relationships more flavorful. Debaters might even reframe it as an adventurous excursion into someone else's world.

Patient Action

Debaters' wilder theories and concepts are often just that: theories and concepts. But when they offer vague ideas about dinner or muse about some weekend activity (and then forget 10 minutes later), their lack of follow-through may create day-to-day frustration that erodes romance. Alternatively, they might push so hard for their new ideas that they don't allow their Sentinel partners the time they need to weigh the options.

Although Sentinels don't hesitate to take action once they've made a decision, they need adequate time to make decisions in the first place. One solution: Debaters can ensure they allow their Sentinel partners enough time to muse over new ideas and adjust to the possibility of change. If Sentinels give the green light, Debaters can prove their reliability by promptly and predictably launching into action.

Here's a system Debaters can use to effectively share ideas with their Sentinel partners:

- Keep a whiteboard in a frequented part of the home. Divide it into two columns.
    - After you suggest an idea to your partner, rather than pushing for a response, jot down the idea in the left-hand column (for example, "Trip to France?").
    - Your Sentinel partner can record their thoughts in the right-hand column when they're ready (for example, "Trip to Nice in the spring" or "Maybe something more budget-friendly."
- Once your Sentinel partner has weighed in, it's time for a conversation about next steps. Who can do what to put the idea into action?
- Finally, take prompt action on the tasks that fall under your purview, as a way of demonstrating your trustworthiness and commitment.

When Debaters record their ideas on a whiteboard, Sentinels can take their time to weigh different options, adjust to possible changes, and respond once they're ready. By embarking on the exercise, Debaters can gain a system for preserving their ideas that otherwise fade away ("Remember that time we talked about...?"), and Sentinels can gain time to reflect before they pass judgment on their partners' ideas.

Debater-Explorer Relationships

Debater-Explorer couples know how to steer clear of the ruts and routines that put a damper on so many long-term relationships. They don't agree on everything, but they share a willingness to explore

alternative options and to shake up the status quo. In balanced romances, that willingness fuels their initial attraction – and enables them to move on from arguments and develop fulfilling, lasting relationships.

Balanced Debater-Explorer Relationships

Problem-Solving Pair

What sets Debater-Explorer relationships apart is the way curiosity fuels their ambition. In the early stages of their courtship, Debaters might fall in love with the way Explorers gladly tackle big challenges and the unknown, such as learning a new musical instrument or mastering a new tool – all without making a big deal of it. Meanwhile, Debaters' relentless desire to solve problems and improve the status quo speaks to Explorers' renegade hearts.

As these couples evolve and mature, they become problem-solving teams, trusting in their ability to tackle whatever is in their way – and, most importantly, to do it *together*. Debaters develop deep gratitude for Explorers' willingness to jump in and get their hands dirty, recognizing that trait as an important counterbalance to their tendency to analyze rather than act. In return, Explorers develop abiding respect for Debater lovers who manage to connect their ideas to something practical and immediately useful, especially if it improves their shared lives.

Seriously Open

During the dating phase, Explorers' unusual combination of spontaneity and practicality can fire up Debaters. Owners of adventurous imaginations themselves, Debaters aren't quite as comfortable in novel, real-time situations as their Explorer lovers. To offset their hyper-analytical nature, Debaters may indulge in some of Explorers' loose, fun-loving attitudes – particularly if they can find a good reason to do so.

As romance develops and these couples face major life decisions – like getting married, buying a house, or having children – the two grow to appreciate each other's comfort with disregarding social conventions. These couples don't wither under the weight of traditional gender roles

or measures of success, and they aren't afraid to grant each other some space. This comes in handy when they become so obsessed with their individual projects that they seem almost entirely detached from their home lives. These couples enjoy their time together as well as their time apart.

Debaters and Explorers think on their feet in different ways. If they can tap into both ways in service of their love for each other, they're more likely to find satisfying romantic lives together. Debaters bring fresh, exciting ideas to the table, whereas Explorers bring their kinetic versions of ideas to life.

Unbalanced Debater-Explorer Relationships

Who Knows Best?

Despite their independence, Explorers aren't impervious to slights. Debaters must take care not to talk down to Explorer partners, particularly in their explanations. For example, Debaters might assume that their lovers aren't informed about given topics, and ensuing explanations can have the unintended consequence of making Explorers feel disrespected. Debaters must also watch out for any tendency toward harshness. Particularly when Explorers refuse to engage in lofty, abstract discussions or muse about the future, Debaters may unintentionally – or even intentionally – convey to their significant others that their interests lack depth or meaning.

That dynamic can chip away at the emotional bond that holds Debater-Explorer relationships together. Debaters who assume, even subconsciously, that their partners are somehow "lesser" are doing their relationships a disservice by effectively blinding themselves to everything their significant others can offer. As in all relationships, love and respect are essential to longevity.

Whose Responsibility?

Once again, household maintenance rears its ugly head. In Debater-Explorer relationships, household chores and bills may frequently fall on Explorers' shoulders. Alas, Explorers' preference for living in the moment may not necessarily make them the most consistently

responsible people, either. They'll deal with persistent issues, but only when they become absolutely pressing – for example, an overdue bill or a total lack of clean clothes. The result is chaos and unpredictability, which create unnecessary stress, even for these relatively easygoing souls.

Interestingly, these partners have their own unique strengths when it comes to household responsibilities. However, the differences between their approaches mean they might not recognize their lovers' contributions. Because they're relatively future-oriented, Debaters might focus on pre-empting future problems; for example, by paying bills before they come due. They might feel that their Explorer partners aren't doing their fair share, while simultaneously ignoring what Explorers are pitching in (e.g., tackling overflowing laundry baskets as they arise). Meanwhile, Explorers might feel as if they're the only ones doing chores, not noticing or appreciating that their Debater partners keep the water running so the laundry can get washed in the first place.

Rebalancing Debater-Explorer Relationships

Good Complaining

When Debaters assume that their Explorer beloveds are superficial or unknowledgeable, they are invoking one of the "four horsemen of the apocalypse" identified by relationship researcher John Gottman. Specifically, they are using criticism – among the most toxic communication styles in romantic relationships. Paradoxically, if Explorers resist (or roll their eyes at) such judgment, Debaters might feel more inclined to criticize their partners, doing so with greater frequency or force, as well as more damaging effects. That will pave the way for Explorers to react defensively and volley their own recriminations.

Fortunately, their romance isn't doomed. According to Gottman, the antidote to criticism is to complain without blame. For example, "You never want to talk about anything deep or meaningful," might become, "I love to share my ideas with you because you mean so much to me. Up for talking through a big idea?" That way, these partners can still express their feelings and their frustrations – after all, it is never good to bottle those up too tightly – without wounding each other. The other

benefit is that this type of communication opens the door for hands-on fixes, something Explorers can happily identify and implement. Here are some steps to practice "good complaining."

Consider whether a complaint is necessary. Some things simply don't need to be said. When in doubt, wait for one minute before speaking. (Note that this is different from repression. If frustration grows rather than diminishes with time, it probably needs to be expressed.)

- When in doubt, use a casual, good-humored tone. If a complaint is made in a friendly tone, Explorers are more likely to be amused about being called out than offended.
- Make a positive request. In other words, ask for something specific in positive terms. "Can we stop talking about the party?" might become, "Could we talk about an idea of mine for a few minutes?"
- Bear in mind that Explorers crave *doing*, not talking. When appropriate, go on a hike or take a scenic drive to offer a better backdrop for meaningful conversation than hanging around home – fortunately, it's something that appeals to both.

As positive conversations come to outweigh criticisms, Debaters will reacquaint themselves with their Explorer lovers' strengths and gifts. Whatever their challenges, the immediacy and tangibility of Debater-Explorer relationships create deeply moving moments, which can overcome challenges of all scales.

Procrastination Begone

When these couples sense a lack of connection with each other, the issue may have surprisingly tangible roots. Even for these two, heaps of unopened mail, half-finished home-improvement projects, and overflowing trash cans create stress. Add some tension over who should do what, and there's a recipe for frazzled, disconnected lovers.

The time comes, sooner or later, to sit down and pay the bills, and Debaters can actively encourage their Explorer partners – and themselves – to attend to such practical matters. Fortunately, between Explorers' bias toward action and Debaters' ability to plan, they are more than capable of tackling their to-dos. These partners may be

more focused on higher personal goals than laundry, but by forming an understanding and following through, they can support each other's attention to mundane responsibilities.

Here's how Debaters can take an action-oriented approach toward tackling chores with their Explorer partners:

- Choose an item of unfinished business, from dirty dishes in the sink to cluttered surfaces.
- Be spontaneous, seizing small pockets of time such as TV commercial breaks to tackle pressing matters together.
- Set a timer and see how much can be done during that time. (For example, how many shirts can be folded, or how many items of trash can be collected from various surfaces and thrown away?)
- Next, set a timer for an even shorter amount of time and see whether the previous benchmark can be exceeded.
- Commit to tackling the tasks as a team – even creating a team name, if desired. Doing the dishes together can transform it from a tedious chore to a chance to bump shoulders, dance, and laugh.

Powering through chores can be remarkably refreshing, and these couples may find that with the kitchen clean and their bills settled, they suddenly feel freer to live the lives they want.

Conclusion

Clear-Eyed Love

In Debaters' search for romantic connections, they are rarely swayed by superficial factors such as potential partners' attractiveness, social status, or wealth. Nor are they blinded by infatuation or beholden to convenience. Instead, they dive into love with their eyes open, willing to brave uncertainty in pursuit of a relationship's ultimate potential.

It's a common assumption that Thinking types, including Debaters, lack a romantic side, as they endeavor to take an analytical approach to relationships. But Debaters' capacity for love should not be underestimated. They don't end up in relationships by accident, though they may unfold more organically than would be expected of many

Judging types. Rather, they choose partners whom they deeply respect, admire, and trust.

At times, they might struggle to express their feelings through conventional means. Fortunately, by learning what makes their significant others feel loved, they can communicate how much they care in targeted, effective ways – whether by listening actively, making romantic gestures, tackling chores, or trying new activities together. To communicate their affection, Debaters might have to venture beyond their comfort zone, but they're more than up to the challenge.

The Head and the Heart

Going into romance with preconceived expectations may give the illusion of control, but alas, it's only an illusion. No matter how much Debaters might expect their partners to be just like them, the expectation is illogical (not to mention unhelpful). No two people are alike, and relationships are about delighting in differences, not imposing similarities.

Fortunately, whether they find themselves with other Analysts or completely different types, Debaters can use their open-mindedness and their incisive imaginations to better understand and embrace their lovers. When built upon a foundation of love and respect, their relationships flourish in beautiful ways. Through romantic partnerships, Debaters can explore new experiences; embrace diverse points of view; and foster mutual understanding, support, and esteem with the people they love.

Friendships

Energizing Engagement

Debaters seek friendships that offer mental engagement and the chance to share new experiences. They want intellectual friends who understand their creativity and keep up with them; they tend to become disenchanted by those who can't. Debaters do best with friends with whom they can explore ideas, bouncing them briskly – and sometimes competitively – back and forth like a game of mental basketball. People with this personality type are always thinking, searching, and contesting what is or might be, and they feel most comfortable with friends who can not only hold their own in conversation but also appreciate Debaters' mental gymnastics.

For those who can keep up, Debaters are a delightful and exciting presence, offering fantastic storytelling, vivid conversations, and spirited debates. Experiences are also crucial to this type, whether drinking wine on an Italian beach, hanging out with friends in the bright lights of a large city, or camping in the calming quiet of a forest. They want to hop around the world and bring their friends along with them. However, the key to Debaters' social development is moving beyond sheer excitement and friendly intellectual sparring toward authentic connection.

Refreshingly Honest

Debaters enjoy spending time with people they respect. Some friends build each other up with ego-stroking, but Debaters unabashedly share their truths with little concern over any resulting emotional

impact. Their blunt behavior is intended to be beneficial, though. They challenge their friends to improve and happily offer them constructive observations to help. In an age of gossip, false social veneers, and worship of appearances, Debaters' sharp honesty can be refreshing, if slightly abrasive – like a good scrub.

Although Extraverted, Debaters have no taste for social jockeying or emotional games. They prefer to argue and sway people, and they call out others' faulty facts and logic rather than use emotional manipulation. That can be a positive quality, for even though Debaters may not be the gentlest communicators, their sincerity earns them their friends' trust. By taking time to understand things on a factual level, people with this personality type often serve as logical mirrors for friends and as potent assets in times of trouble. Often seeming to be above the raging waters of emotion, Debaters can lift their friends out of such floods with intellectual and emotional clarity.

Habitual Line-Steppers

Debaters' sarcasm and humor aren't for those who struggle to read between the lines, nor for the faint of heart. Some consider societal norms to be strict rules, but Debaters consider them more as recommendations that they can take or leave. Even when it comes to explicitly stated rules and boundaries, Debaters may find themselves crossing lines if they're inspired to do so. They take things that others deem taboo or incorrect and turn them around, making them interesting, thought-provoking, and worth further exploration.

Although that mindset is amazing when it comes to invention and creation, it has its pitfalls when applied to friendships. It's up to Debaters to act as their own moderators, ensuring that they hear their friends' voices with fair consideration – after all, more than opinions are at stake. Debaters' friendships are at their best when based on intellectual reciprocity, respect, and keen insight, and they'd be wise to put some effort into maintaining such relationships. If their goal is proving personal superiority, deep comradery is unlikely to flourish, as competitiveness and kindness are at odds. On the other hand, when the aims of friendship are to improve and learn, Debaters and their friends can focus on a supportive tone during their exchanges. Then

they can create a road of mutual growth on which they can happily walk together for a long time.

Playing to Strengths and More

When discussing Debaters and friendship, the goal isn't to force them into being warm figures open to all emotions or to make them seek countless heart-to-heart encounters. That's just not who they are. Their strengths lie elsewhere.

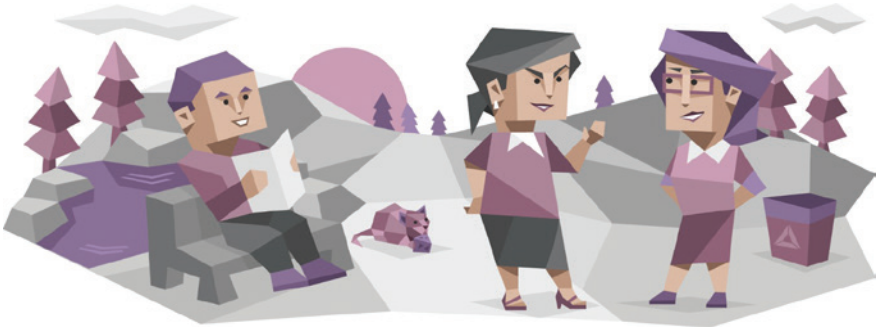
Their skills involve appreciating rationality and using it to cut to the chase, and there's no reason to abandon that by favoring more emotional components of friendships. Debaters who want to grow their friendships need not change their essential selves. In fact, trying to deny their strengths is likely to backfire in the long run. Growth is about expanding one's comfort zone. When they add factors to balance out their sometimes less-than-diplomatic social impulses, Debaters can remain true to themselves while they grow as friends. The following sections will discuss multiple ways they can improve.

Debaters and Friends from Other Role Groups

Debaters tend to have inquiring natures, and their analytical yet adaptable minds help them relate to different people in different ways. Although some aspects of the Debater personality can be more help or hindrance when they make and maintain friendships with other personality types, with a little flexibility and patience, everyone has something to offer through any friendship.

We will now examine the tendencies that are most likely to affect Debaters when they are relating to friends in all four Role groups – other Analysts, Diplomats, Sentinels, and Explorers – and look at some ways of balancing their interplay to help create beneficial, fair, and fulfilling companionships.

Debater-Analyst Friendships



Debaters and other Analysts share the Intuitive and Thinking traits, lending a kinship that mitigates whatever might otherwise hinder their friendships. Combining a preference for a rational approach plus a passion for big ideas can create a platform for potentially powerful camaraderie. Such attachment may feel like "home" to Debaters. However, having similarities is no guarantee of a seamless bond. Having friends who are too like themselves can narrow their focus and reduce opportunities for growth. Being too comfortable with only the familiar can obscure development – something that Debaters strive toward.

Balanced Debater-Analyst Friendships

Mutual Invigoration

In friendship, other Analysts are a quick fit for Debaters, sharing their passion for new ideas, knowledge, and unconventional thought. Such friendships are based on intellectual engagement more than social or emotional support, which is how Debaters like it. They may have grown accustomed to feeling frustrated or bored with the world's conventional ways, so friendships with other Analysts are a breath of fresh air.

That fresh air comes in handy because these friends never run out of things to talk – or argue – about. Debaters' minds are always buzzing with analyses, questions, and ideas, and few other types besides Analysts can keep up, much less hold up their own counterarguments. In balanced friendships, Debaters and Analysts love bouncing ideas back and forth, and their intellectual prowess enables them to dissect each other's ideas piece by piece, an oddly enjoyable process. These

friendships are characterized by pleasant competition, with a mutual challenge to establish stronger foundations for their thoughts.

Intellectual Partners in Crime

Discussions between Debaters and Analysts who take an open, fair-minded approach are unlikely to revolve around people, feelings, or social status. Instead, they gravitate toward esoteric topics, ideas, and plans, playing together in the theoretical realm. They also usually have compatible senses of humor, making hours of fun and laughter very likely as they improvise, joke, and comment on the world around them. Analyst friends let Debaters be themselves and pursue their interests with little or no inhibition – and perhaps enthusiastic support.

The two also support each other well when seeking answers to life's problems, bringing their greatest creativity together for the sake of mutual well-being. When Debaters and Analysts form healthy, balanced friendships, they can go far together.

Unbalanced Debater-Analyst Friendships

Talking Instead of Communicating

Sharp minds don't always agree, and when Debaters and other Analysts differ on core issues, it can incite a war of words. Debaters' Prospecting trait helps them adapt to new information, but even these curious, discerning people may find themselves in dispute with Analyst friends in less-than-friendly ways. When taking an unbalanced approach to communication, Debaters adapt to their opponents' arguments in ways that allow them to constantly undermine the opposition while sidestepping their own flaws. But doing battle with statistics and philosophies can quickly turn from stimulating to frustrating.

The ensuing fallout can look different depending on their Analyst friends. If their Analyst chums have the Judging trait, Debaters' constant derailment of a topic can frustrate them, or they'll find it irritating when Debaters take every sound idea and add superfluous "what ifs." Analyst friends with the Introversion trait may find that because they take their time to speak, Debaters leave them behind – either out of impatience or because they mistake their Introverted friends' deliberate thinking

as an unwillingness to respond. Overeager Debaters sometimes turn a dialogue into a monologue.

Intellectually Bonded, Emotionally Isolated

Communication can be challenging on more than an intellectual level for Debaters with Analyst pals, as both tend to guard their emotions, and they're unlikely to open up to each other about personal matters. When emotionally charged situations do arise, whether tension within friendships or personal problems, Debaters don't crave or offer profuse apologies, pity, or hugs. In many cases, they appreciate a matter-of-fact exchange of ideas. But Debater-Analyst friends who have yet to decide to address their emotional isolation may wonder how to offer each other adequate support when it's needed – and even the most rational people do need it from time to time.

Debaters, and Analysts in general, are more likely than other types to objectify matters that need emotional intelligence rather than clever solutions. However, they are as vulnerable as anyone else to life events that assault the emotions. They are just as likely to need a friend in times of distress as anyone, and this dynamic, no matter how badly needed, may be absent in Debater-Analyst friendships.

Take, for example, a death in the family. People can examine and discuss death and create many models for grieving. However, all the explanations and solutions in the world won't lessen the pain or the difficult adjustments to a new normal. Mourners must experience grief and pass through its stages. As friends, Debaters might attempt to explain suffering away, but sometimes only time and friendly support will do.

Rebalancing Debater-Analyst Friendships

Shifting to Greater Cooperation

When engaging with a friend, Debaters may ask themselves, "What can I learn from this person?" Debaters can approach interactions with Analysts (or anyone of a differing mindset) as learning opportunities instead of threats to their own settled perspective. If there's one passion Debaters undeniably have, it's their zeal for discovering new

ideas and perspectives. They're intrigued by people who shed new light on their assumptions and advance their thinking, which leads to easy companionship with other Analysts. Their open method means Debaters aren't obliged to accept what doesn't make sense to them. Instead, they can examine other Analysts' points of view for useful nuggets of insight, respectfully coexisting with people whose opinions differ.

When it comes to disagreements, one excellent way for Debaters and their Analyst friends to evolve past conflict is shared experimentation. These friends can support each other's attempts to bring ideas into reality and gain the resulting useful experience. Working with open minds, Debaters and Analysts can shelve arguments about "ideal solutions," then discover the empirical evidence together. Debaters love to experiment and learn, and chasing data with friends may be doubly enjoyable, providing useful knowledge and building stronger bonds through cooperation.

One experiment Debaters can try with a friend they frequently disagree with: Play a game to help each other build an argument from a non-adversarial perspective:

- Choose any topic to explore with a friend.
- Strike the right attitude by deciding to expand on the topic without dissenting or taking a contrary stance. Just for this exercise, suspend disagreement. Think of it as the opposite of a debate.
- Start with a single proposition. It can a serious topic or a light-hearted one. Some examples:
  - "Owning pets is a form of slavery and must be abolished."
  - "Pineapple on pizza isn't appropriate."
  - "Artificial intelligence puts humans in danger."
- Flip a coin to decide who is Player A and who is Player B.
- Set a timer for five minutes.
- Player A makes the first statement about the proposition. The first statement can be "pro" or "con" and should be no longer than a single sentence.

- Player B then responds by expanding Player A's statement. To ensure this, their response must begin with, "Yes, and ..."
- Continue developing the original response until the timer runs out.

Although this game won't test a proposition to its full extent, pushback is often a productive way to arrive at a substantive conclusion. Testing ideas against opposing ones can be a powerful means of arriving at truth. But a friendship can become exhausting if that's all it's about. Taking a breath and finding a cooperative tone can help friends remain positive, and it balances debate with a healthy sense of camaraderie.

The Role of Emotional Intelligence

Debaters and other Analysts might argue in favor of Descartes' famous quote, "I think; therefore, I am," but a common counterargument alleges that it's severely limiting to say that people are no more than their thoughts. Intellect is important, but strict rationality has its limits. When individuals recognize and nurture their emotional sides, they can fortify their friendships and understand themselves – and life itself – better. It's a mistake to construct a false dichotomy that claims a strict separation between rationality and emotions. The overlap is too great, and emotions contain their own logic and usefulness. Dismissing them can inhibit growth, both personally and within friendships.

To build higher emotional intelligence requires being in touch with one's own emotions and acknowledging and respecting the emotions of others. Friendship can strengthen both. It's a mistake to consider Debaters and other Analysts unfeeling. Although they are often less comfortable or less fluent in expressing emotion than other types are, they're no less capable. That said, learning to "speak the language," even within such an intellectual friendship, can add another dimension to their bond.

Here's a game they can play to raise emotional awareness.

Equipment:

- A dart
- A dartboard
- Post-It notes (or any other adhesive labels)

How to play:

- Arrange a list of "emotion" words on the board in any fashion. The words might include: hope, trust, fear, joy, surprise, disgust, anger, sadness, remorse, love, anticipation, frustration, or any number of others. (This is also a great chance to play with a nuanced vocabulary.)
- From an eight-foot distance from the board, about the regulation distance for an official game, throw the dart. (Throwing with your eyes closed, using adequate safety precautions, will increase randomness.)
- The player should tell a story or anecdote about a time they felt the emotion they hit with the dart, including what they did in response to it. Avoid judging or analyzing anything. The only goal is awareness through observation.

Emotional intelligence isn't static. People can cultivate and increase their empathy, mostly through awareness and a willingness to grow. This game can serve to raise awareness. Debater and Analyst friends can "up their game" by realizing there's more of value in life than endless intellectual discussion and debate, and their camaraderie can reflect that truth. Neither is in danger of losing their love for the rational – but they can still acknowledge that they do indeed *love* it.

Debater-Diplomat Friendships

The common threads in Debater-Diplomat friendships are their passion for ideas and their drive to imagine improved lives. Neither binds themselves to the world as it is, and both love to explore unrealized

potential. They may have dissimilar concerns – Debaters cling to rationality, whereas Diplomats prefer compassion – but their imaginative styles still offer plenty of commonalities, often more than enough to create companionship.

Balanced Debater-Diplomat Friendships

Imagination and Idealism

Debaters can find ways to take Diplomat idealism and bend it toward something they can implement, as well as coax their Diplomat friends out of their shells. Sharing the Intuitive trait, Debaters and Diplomats see beyond the superficial and enjoy ideations about a better world. The main difference between the two is that Diplomats view the world in terms of humanism and hopeful ideals, whereas Debaters, even though still focused on humans and what they're doing, are less interested in the emotional aspect of humanity and more interested in the optimization of it.

Debaters who choose to be accepting often find that Diplomats are full of fresh ideas, and to encounter a new perspective as insightful and creative as their own, yet very different, fascinates them. Debaters efficiently illuminate whatever might work best, and Diplomats add a humanistic dimension to bring people together for the greatest possible outcome. When these friends use their strengths in tandem, mixing rational ideas and high ideals, they become a mighty force for the common interest.

Learning Compassion

On a more personal level, Debaters who are open to developing life skills can exchange some truly significant qualities with their Diplomat friends. With their enthusiastic logic, Debaters can be a wonderfully contrasting influence in Diplomats' lives, offering reasoned thinking that helps them focus their passionate energy. From their Diplomat pals, Debaters can gain revelatory dimensions of emotional insight, helping them explore the complex mysteries of human interactions – and themselves. These friends have the potential to lead each other to tremendous personal growth.

Efficiency without compassion is a lonely and hard thing. Compassion without rationality meanders from one unbridled feeling to another. Friends who complement each other in these areas are valuable companions, and there's much potential for camaraderie between Debaters and Diplomats.

Unbalanced Debater-Diplomat Friendships

Constant Tension

When choosing to be unaccepting (or, as happens to everyone, when being a bit thoughtless), Debaters think of strong emotional expression as extraneous – something to be dealt with rather than honored. Such a mindset can be confusing or even offensive to Diplomats, who consider emotion a vital part of living and connecting with others. Unfortunately, Debaters are unlikely to give their Diplomat friends the emotional support they need.

These differences affect unbalanced Debater-Diplomat friendships in very personal ways: Debaters have little desire to discuss their feelings, and Diplomats sense this with regret, leaving them wishing for closer friendships. On the other hand, Diplomats' freer emotions strike Debaters as unnecessary, immature, imprudent, or just a bother. Conflicting, unbalanced approaches to the human experience may cause Debaters to criticize their Diplomat friends and Diplomat friends to question Debaters' hearts.

Unintended Consequences

If riled, Debaters may do unintended damage. With an unbalanced approach, Debaters can disparage Diplomats' gentler view of the world with their typically unrestrained arguing. The resulting rift may penetrate deeply and become difficult to repair. Debaters may be thoughtless with their words, unaware of the impact their observations can have on Diplomats. Likewise, if Diplomats lash out at Debaters in a moment of pique, their rash words may be taken as enduring statements of fact, making Debaters resistant to later apologies. Both can be wounded, although in different ways.

Both can also take themselves too seriously. Debaters need to be free to express their thoughts. They don't necessarily want others to agree with their concepts – they gladly accept criticism (and often enjoy it!) from people they judge worthy to offer it – but they won't accept someone minimizing or questioning the quality of their efforts. Diplomats' underlying sense of moral virtue radiates like a halo behind their outlooks, which can give their criticisms the weight to challenge not only facts but the very morality of their Debater friends. If either disrespects what the other holds dear, it's likely to result in a grave injury to their friendships. Luckily, these friends can avoid most serious conflicts if they maintain a heightened perspective, which is easily within their abilities.

Rebalancing Debater-Diplomat Friendships

From Tension to Understanding

Understanding is the key to managing any tension that arises between Debater and Diplomat friends. Respecting each other's distinct styles is important, but before one can develop respect, it's necessary to know exactly *what* they should respect. For Debaters, they can develop a healthy understanding of the humanistic and emotional aspects of life that their Diplomat friends care so much about. Until they do, their affection will remain superficial, and they will likely find it difficult to sustain what one calls "friendship."

Debaters favor logical reasoning over emotional appeals; that being said, they can develop the ability to validate their friends' humanistic strengths and see the value in gentleness. To do so, they must put themselves in situations that require emotional exposure and confront their own feelings. Debaters might consider volunteering to serve the disadvantaged (e.g., a soup kitchen) or mentoring children through standard tutoring or job shadowing. When they interact with more vulnerable individuals, they need to understand that emotions may play a part in fulfilling their role.

Here are some steps these friends can take toward emotional validation.

- Together, find a volunteer role that matches the descriptions above.

- Coordinate your schedules to ensure that you volunteer at the same time.
- Go about your duties.
- If faced with a difficult or emotionally confusing situation, ask for assistance from your Diplomat friend.
- Observe how your Diplomat friend responds to the situation.
- Ask yourself:
    - What are positive takeaways from your friend's response?
    - How can you integrate these positive takeaways into your own response style?

There's a practical benefit to this exercise, as Debaters can use it to bolster their résumés. However, the best takeaway is that, in the end, they will learn to value the emotional insight that Diplomats can lend. Many situations deal with complex and raw emotions, which Debaters sometimes struggle to interpret. Once they come to understand the value of Diplomats' perspective, they can look to strengthen their friendships with them based on genuine admiration.

Grasping Alternate Perspectives

Debaters and Diplomats strive for similar results: to develop ideas about a better world and make them reality. Respecting such shared values may help these friends balance out their differing approaches and their consequent sensitivities.

Friendships are likely to flourish if Debaters and Diplomats each honor what the other brings to the table. Diplomats' warm care can be a balm to the intellectual – and, at times, self-destructive – conflicts in Debaters' lives, and the thoughtful insight and logic offered by Debaters may be a lifeline to Diplomat friends who struggle with indecision caused by their humanistic qualities. Most of all, the two can share an unending dance of inspiration, grasping different sides of an idea as they raise it to the heights of creativity together. To do this, Debaters can step into the shoes of their friends and try to understand the world from a different perspective. Here's an exercise that can help:

- Ask a Diplomat friend (or friends) to recommend a news story that interested them, then read or watch that story.
- Using what you know about Diplomats, step into their shoes for a moment and explore how they might respond to the story. How might a Diplomat react? What would be their focus? What solutions might an Intuitive, Feeling individual come up with?
- Then ponder: How might a Debater react differently? How might a Debater influenced by a Diplomat respond?
- Consider: What would be a balanced response be (combining Thinking and Feeling reactions)?
- Then take the exercise outside of the theoretical and run your findings past your Diplomat friend.

If nothing else, this exercise can lead to fascinating conversations about both the news story and the reflections. The goal isn't to turn Debaters into Diplomats. Even if that were the goal, that sort of change isn't possible. But Debaters and Diplomats alike can enrich their lives and respond more effectively to their surroundings if they adopt some of each other's characteristics. After all, growth comes from expanding beyond one's comfort zone.

Debater-Sentinel Friendships

Debaters are likely to dive right into friendships with Sentinels, particularly those with the Thinking trait. Sentinels, however, may need to warm up to Debaters' exuberant and energized persona, which is why the two often take time to develop a rapport. Friendships between Debaters and Sentinels often emerge due to circumstance – they are

coworkers, for example. When they first meet, they don't always understand what seem like obvious limits in the other's approach to life. However, Debater friends can expand Sentinels' thinking with their opportunistic tendencies, and Sentinel friends can anchor often-impulsive Debaters in the practical. Mutual appreciation of the gifts each brings to the table can produce long-lasting and satisfying friendship.

Balanced Debater-Sentinel Friendships

Inspirational Perspectives

Debaters may find that Sentinels complement them well as friends. Sentinels are often impressed by Debaters' insight, their compulsion to make everything work better, and their cleverness at imagining the broader mechanics of a solution. They might look to Sentinels for practical advice on a step-by-step path toward their grand ideas and, in turn, help Sentinels expand the scope of their thinking.

When Debaters and Sentinels befriend each other, it isn't some partnership organized around their different strengths. Friendships are more organic. But their personalities naturally influence all that they do, and friendship is no exception. A conversation between the two might find Debaters exploring ideas that are refreshingly novel to their Sentinel friends. Conversely, Sentinels can help Debaters enjoy reality in a casual, friendly way, with questions and propositions ranging from "You know what would be interesting to do today?" to "The world would be a better place if..."

Trading Mindsets

Debaters poke and prod by nature, and they will turn over every stone in the name of innovation. They're bound only by the rules of rational potential. For them, ideas become stale quickly, and their need for revision leaves their thinking in constant flux. They seek adventure and action. Meanwhile, Sentinels are happy to tend the hearth, metaphorically – they maintain order at home. Generally, Debaters can be considered "fierce activators," whereas Sentinels are often "organized doers."

Debaters might shake up Sentinels' settled thinking by questioning their traditional values and ideas. If Debaters are gentle and respectful enough in their challenges, and if they don't attempt to convert their friends to their latest ideas or opinions, it is a valuable exercise. Sentinels might even enjoy new perspectives on things they've taken for granted. Debaters also benefit from looking closely at those very perspectives, gaining insight into a grounded world. The purpose of friendships isn't for companions to transform each other. Nonetheless, it's common to say friends can be "good" for each other. This speaks to the growth potential available through exposure, and there are plenty of chances for such growth in Debater-Sentinel friendships.

Unbalanced Debater-Sentinel Friendships

Inconsiderate of Sensibilities

When Debaters and Sentinels decide they like each other, it doesn't mean they always *understand* each other – their foci can be very different. Debaters love to discuss things with convoluted humor, to execute wild ideas and improbable schemes. Sentinels are likely to focus on more direct, substantial experiences, even when it comes to something as light and friendly as recreational pursuits. These friends may need to compromise when sharing casual time together – and they need to be willing to work hard to expand and stand together on any common ground that naturally exists between them so that they can keep things lively and engage in ways that are accessible to both.

This can make a difference on a typical night out. For example, when watching a movie for entertainment alone, Debaters may not take it at face value and focus more on pointing out inconsistencies. Although they may consider dissection of the film entertaining, their Sentinel friends may not agree, finding it annoying when Debaters pick apart a film that was never meant to be a think piece. When Debaters are reluctant to be respectful of Sentinels' sensibilities (in this case, a form of entertainment), it's likely to raise tensions and dampen any enthusiasm these friends have for each other. Insisting on one's own preferences or judging the preferences of others can create conflict in any kind of relationship, including friendship. There's enough difference between

these two that overplaying one's own traits at the cost of the other's preferences can be damaging.

The Responsible Friend

Even though a friendship can be as casual as "hanging out," it's still a relationship, and relationships sometimes fall into roles. Because Debaters lag behind Sentinels in organizing and carrying out plans, Sentinels often dutifully assume the role of the "responsible" pal. It's fine if both accept and embrace the roles. However, any division of labor between them may look like Debaters have saddled their Sentinel friends with the mundane work. After all, securing a reservation at a popular restaurant takes time and effort, and it can be frustrating when Debaters ignore the behind-the-scenes efforts that go into making such things possible. Debaters may imagine a "spontaneous" night out on the town, but Sentinels plan ahead by researching venues, considering budget, arranging transportation, and more. Feelings of inequity can unexpectedly seep into these friendships.

In their excitement ahead of a good time, Debaters can forget the groundwork needed. Sentinels don't mind doing their part, and they often even insist on it. But nobody likes to do *all* the heavy lifting. Although Debaters are engaged and insightful types, they sometimes get carried away with what's going to happen – but miss important details. Their focus simply remains on bigger ideas at the expense of more practical matters. But unless the difference is communicated effectively, it may look like an abdication of responsibility – especially to duty-sensitive Sentinels.

Rebalancing Debater-Sentinel Friendships

Respecting Sensibilities

When judgment harms the relationship between Debaters and Sentinels, repairing their bond may require acknowledging the boundaries between their shared and private lives. Each person has the right to live as they see fit and need only be concerned with compromise when they spend time together. What seems like a limited existence to Debaters may, in fact, bring great joy, prosperity, and personal growth

to Sentinels, and what looks like idealistic chaos to Sentinels may be a life of satisfying accomplishment for Debaters. Arguing over who's "right" is a fruitless endeavor when each may need different things to be happy.

Neither needs to accept the other person's ways for themselves, but it's important that they respect their friends' preferences and avoid imposing their own choices upon them. Conflicting styles only clash when they meet, and reasons for friction disappear when these friends take care to contribute positively to each other's lives. It's also important for them to quash any judgment with honest communication, before things get snide or heated. Expressing critical concern for each other is different from dispensing judgment; both should feel empowered to speak up when they feel that line has been crossed.

A simple exercise for Debaters and Sentinels to ease judgments over their differences is to overlay them with positive actions that recognize each other's virtues, even if they are dissimilar. Here are some helpful steps:

- Privately, write five to 10 beneficial things that the other friend brings to the relationship (e.g., great humor, willingness to drive, a sense of caring, fun ideas for activities, always reliable, keeps secrets between them, gives good advice, buys coffee, cooks great food, solves problems).
- Watch for instances of these positive acts, adjusting the list as needed.
- Show verbal appreciation for each instance.
- Mention the feelings created by each positive act; keep it brief and casual.

Debaters and Sentinels have some inescapable and marked core differences, but there's no reason they can't enjoy deep and happy friendship together where their interests overlap. Caring for each other gives them a reason to compromise and to respect their need to be themselves.

Mutual Responsibility

Rebalancing their different approaches to activities requires a little compromise and tolerance. Sentinel partners can learn to be more flexible when their Debater friends want them to join in an inspired idea, and Debaters can make sure Sentinels have a say in how they engage in the activity together. Sometimes Sentinels just need a moment to get their heads around an idea before they proceed. If they're given that time, they may gladly follow their Debater friends into the fun.

Highly adaptable, Debaters can use their go-with-the-flow energy to give Sentinels leeway in planning out such activities together, including accepting some scheduling. Patience doesn't always come easily to Debaters, but they may have better results when they are easygoing instead of pushy. They can lead with ready energy and ideas – but respect the pace of their Sentinel friends. Below are some steps that can help enable workable compromises:

- Pitch a fun idea and inform your Sentinel friend that the experience must be "spontaneous."
- Agree on a timetable that suits both.
- Communicate needs clearly and cheerfully.
- If suggesting a change to a plan, be respectful, and don't force the issue.
- Try and adapt to each other's needs when spending time together.

Both can take a step into each other's timeframes now and then – they each have a good approach for certain things. When it comes to having fun, Sentinels may find unexpected relief when they let go of rigid control, and Debaters can appreciate the benefits of staying on schedule when it comes to important matters.

Debater-Explorer Friendships

Although Debaters and Explorers can be dissimilar, those who become friends share a similar energy based on spontaneity. One entertains borderline-obsessive ideas springing from theories, whereas the other pursues a succession of novel experiences. The Prospecting trait provides the energy for both, influencing them to constantly change direction or find new facets of their existing interests to explore. Understanding and harnessing these tendencies can provide common ground for lasting friendship as the spontaneous thinker joins forces with the spontaneous actor.

Balanced Debater-Explorer Friendships

Spontaneous Collaborators

Debater-Explorer friendships have much potential, especially if the two share common interests. Debaters often struggle to let go of their intellectual poking and can sometimes be overwhelmed by all the things they cannot do. When this happens, they can look to their Explorer friends to help them let it go so they can follow their hearts (and Prospecting tendencies) with unworried enthusiasm. As Debaters are pulled into the fray, they can add their trademark "What if we try..." attitude to the mix, expanding their Explorer friends' options even further.

This is the real beauty of Debater-Explorer friendships: Debaters have so many ideas about what's possible, and spontaneous Explorers can prompt them to act without becoming mired in theory or hamstrung by the scope of their vision and ambitions. Explorers are masters of "one step at a time." If these friends share a common hobby or

field of interest, even better. They can collaborate with their unique contributions and share endless fun.

Beyond Obvious Usefulness

Differing types can encourage personal growth for their friends. This goes beyond just being useful and balancing each other in obvious ways. Explorers typically hate theory – yet there's value in ideas. Debaters don't always think about fulfilling their ideas to completion. However, bonds between Debaters and Explorers can involve influencing each other and nudging by example.

When both go along for the friendship ride, they pick up subtle changes to their own styles that reflect those of their friends. Rather than overt utilitarian compromise leading to distinct actions, sometimes the gifts of their relationships are their contributions to their companions' growth. Some speakers in the self-help field claim that individuals are composites of the five individuals with whom they spend the most time. The number is subject to debate, but it's hard to deny that the prominent people in one's life can be a significant influence. Debaters aren't likely to change Explorers into members of their own type or the other way around – nor should anyone try. However, an almost subliminal influence can be part of personal growth.

Unbalanced Debater-Explorer Friendships

Differing Levels of Engagement

Debaters may see Explorers' tendency to live in the present and follow their compulsions as shortsighted, and they may disapprove of Explorers' decision-making in general. Even though Explorers might entertain the riskiest adventures, their forward-thinking imaginations usually forestall disaster. Debaters rely on a great deal more discussion ahead of their actions, though more for fun than need. But a steady stream of talk can wear down Explorers, who are more intent on getting their hands dirty right away.

With shared activities, Debaters can become baffled and concerned when Explorer friends get caught up in the drama or pleasure of the moment, taking no time for critical reflection. However, they'll likely

find no rational explanation from Explorers, who simply move on to the next thing before the dust settles. If Debaters spend too much time thinking without jumping in, Explorers may just leave them in the dust. A lack of foundation for communication can lead these pals to become out of sync with each other.

Misinterpreted Humor

Debaters value seeing "above" things; therefore, they tend to have a sense of wit and humor where boundaries are made for breaking. Rather than serious-minded pontification, Debaters more often make light of the "little" things that Explorers take seriously. For instance, if an Explorer spends a lot of time tinkering with their car, they won't have much patience for Debater friends joking about the expense and inefficiency of such a hobby, nor wry comments about the pollution that cars cause.

Because Explorers take things at immediate face value, any jokes that belittle their passion can endanger a friendship. Debaters, gregarious though they are, may find that their humor proves to be a double-edged sword.

Rebalancing Debater-Explorer Friendships

Knowing When to Be Permissive

In their desire for progress, Debaters often try to impact as many people as possible, but even the most social of Explorers tend to focus on satisfying their own goals, even while they enjoy the company of other people and care for their friends. Neither should be made to feel judged for this difference. It's important for Debaters to realize that not everyone shares their boundless ideation, and the difference is acceptable. Although Debaters can always invite Explorer friends into their broader efforts toward their ideals, it's not fair to make it seem obligatory. Debaters can use their great ability for forward thinking to see when Explorer friends simply don't share their interests, then decide to let them off the hook.

In turn, Explorers can tap into their famous curiosity and try something new, even if it doesn't initially seem very interesting. "Why would I

bother doing that?" is a common question; the answer comes from the realization that good friends are worth extra effort – and that together anything can be fun. Explorers often have great success once they set their sights on something, and they can tune in to Debaters' enthusiasm and pitch in with their company. Such efforts are very meaningful to Debaters and affirm these friendships.

Allowing each other their own directions in life, especially when it comes to perceived societal obligations versus personal priorities, is a necessary and fair manifestation of respect in these alliances. Ultimately, how they feel when they spend time together is more important than doing everything together, so independence is sometimes the best option. To help preserve balance, both Debaters and Explorers can use these tips:

- Invite each other into personal priorities with enthusiasm. Highlight the possible fun and benefits for each other: "We could" instead of "You should."
- Try and be open-minded about joining in things your friends care about.
- Give things a fair shot at least once before dismissing them as boring or irrelevant.
- When either person declines to do something, be understanding – no need to ask for a reason, but perhaps inquire, "Is there anything I could do to help?"
- Give each other space and freedom to pursue personal priorities without judgment – different strokes for different folks.

These two often become friends thanks to areas of overlap and commonality, and trying to drag each other too far out of that zone can be disrespectful. Instead, they can better spend their energy in areas of common interest, reveling in what can be happily shared together as often as possible.

Explaining the Joke

Debaters have a unique sense of humor that may not resonate with everyone. They can find humor in everything – themselves, their

failures, and even difficult and traditionally taboo subjects. Because of this, some people may mistake their attempts at light-hearted poking for ill intentions. Explorers, who find value in things immediately in front of them, can feel hurt should they believe that Debaters are mocking the activities or ideas they care so much about. However, Debaters, with their quick-acting wit and intuition, can quickly spot a shift in Explorer friends' attitudes or demeanor. If Explorers express their hurt, Debaters can do the following:

- Make a joke about yourself. This shows your Explorer friend that any teasing isn't specific to them – but aimed at everything.
- Explain what you really meant by the joke. This can be along the lines of, "I didn't mean anything by it. I just thought it would be funny to say."
- Reassure your Explorer friend that you respect their passions and ideas, even if you don't personally like or adopt them.

Debaters and Explorers aren't the same people. Each has their own ideas and preferences, which both highly respect, though they may express their respect and passion in different ways. That is why it's important for Debaters to communicate how they express themselves – often through benignly intended humor.

Conclusion

Social Activators

We've discussed some pitfalls Debaters may face in friendships, but in truth, this personality type is incredibly adept at creating and maintaining social relationships by choice. They can find something to appreciate in any type, valuing people as individuals and reflexively extending enthusiasm and excitement. When Debaters meet worthy people and invest in deeper friendships, their bright, active imaginations; outgoing nature; and uninhibited inclinations give them substantial charm, which they share freely and honestly.

Given their highly adaptable and innovative social abilities, Debaters face difficulties in friendships that are partly their own creation. Like all Intuitive types, they may become so blinded by their own expansive visions that they lose touch with basic, everyday factors, including other

people's perfectly natural limits and differences. Debaters are so good at sharing their energy with others that when someone isn't so easily caught up or influenced, they may view it as a failure – or as a signal that the individual needs a remedy for who they inherently are.

When Debaters grow enough to accept other people for the unique qualities they bring to friendships, they themselves spend less time contradicting and more time having fun with people – and learning from them. When they project the underlying tone of fun and excitement that comes so naturally to them, they can enjoy the company of anyone: Dreamy idealists, reserved traditionalists, and self-assured gadabouts are all equally charmed. Truly, Debaters have the potential to create fulfilling social relationships in their lives, if that's what they choose.

Parenthood

Enjoying a Challenge

There are few things in life more challenging than raising children to be productive, positive members of society, and people with the Debater personality type love a good challenge. They enjoy fixing problems – even their own personal weaknesses – and taking charge of another person's life can reveal weaknesses quickly. Debaters who understand the importance of their influence take the role of parent seriously, and they're often profoundly affected by this aspect of their lives.

People with this personality type enjoy the personal challenges of parenthood. They often believe that the best way to promote their kids' growth is through intellectual challenges of their own, so they tend to eagerly provide their children with learning opportunities in hopes of sparking their thoughts, ideas, and beliefs. By presenting challenges in loving and informative ways, Debater parents can help their sons and daughters become better informed and encourage them to seek knowledge – even if it's to prove a point to their parents.

Promoting Independence

Debaters' preference for avoiding rules and regulations is evident, and they give their children the freedom to explore on their own. Independence is one of their greatest needs, and they believe that no one is complete without an independent mind. At their best, these parents create relaxed, unorthodox environments for their children, founded on enthusiasm and the joy of discovery through the development of reason – not heavily structured settings designed to be safe.

They encourage their children to think independently and voice objections, opinions, and alternatives. Debaters teach their kids to approach everything from a position of impartiality, to distinguish what is efficient and reasonable from what feels good, and to argue their position fairly and effectively. Even if emotional intelligence isn't their strong suit, Debaters who realize the importance of a healthy emotional understanding in their decision-making process encourage their children to do the same. They recognize that honest discussion comes from understanding.

Strained Emotional Intelligence

As their children grow and work to balance healthy emotional expression with logic, Debater parents who don't take the time to incorporate emotional understanding into their own repertoire may find themselves exasperated. Although they are always up for a debate on almost any subject, they may need help to manage their children's outbursts of feeling. Although they're more permissive than most, even Debaters have their limits and rules when it comes to vocal conflict.

Criticism is one area where Debaters' insensitivity becomes apparent. As parents, they're prone to impatience when their children don't pick up on seemingly obvious ideas or concepts. They may overestimate their kids' abilities and level of understanding and become frustrated when their children don't meet their sometimes-unrealistic expectations. Such criticism can be especially hurtful to children who are sensitive to harsh words. If they don't reign in their tendency for critical commentary, Debaters may struggle with developing close emotional bonds with their children.

Building Emotional Intelligence

Debaters want their children to grow up to be smart, independent, and open-minded. But if they want them to be well-adjusted, too, they must try to provide emotional support, even if it means learning entirely new skills. Though Debaters may struggle to teach empathy alongside rationality, doing so will help their children grow into confident adults who ask questions, think constructively, and take care of themselves no matter what comes their way.

To build their emotional intelligence, Debaters need to take inventory of their strengths and weaknesses, then balance them effectively. In terms of parenting, they benefit from practicing empathy, gaining perspective on their own emotional behavior, and controlling unhelpful impulses. Debater parents, specifically, often need to learn to curb their impulsive criticism when their children don't meet their expectations.

One of the most important things parents can do is take time to realize and accept how their emotions influence their children. By focusing on understanding their kids in a developmentally appropriate way, and by making patience and kindness goals in all interactions with them, Debaters make the best of their role as parents.

Parenting for Each Stage of Development

Each of the stages of children's growth presents unique challenges and exciting milestones. Learning how to navigate the stages can seem daunting, but the opportunity to build healthy attachment and create meaningful memories makes it worth the struggle.

Renowned psychologist Erik Erikson proposed a theory of psychosocial development that identified eight stages, five of which take place between birth and 18 years of age. Keep in mind that the ages listed for each stage are approximate. It's normal for children develop at their own pace and meet each milestone in their own time, sometimes even skipping stages, achieving them in an unexpected order, or trying one milestone and falling back to an old one – especially common with walking. (When it comes to questions about delayed developmental stages, we recommend consulting a pediatrician.)

The following paragraphs discuss what to expect at each stage of development, as well as how the strengths and weaknesses of the Debater personality type affect parenting at each stage.

Building Bonds (Birth–1½ Years)

According to Erikson, the stages of infancy and early childhood last from birth until approximately 3 years of age. Children in these stages are very dependent on their parents. This is when parents can create the bonds of attachment by meeting their children's needs, developing trusting relationships, and eventually promoting autonomy.

The priority for infants on their journey to attachment is having their basic needs met. This is a sensitive time in a parental relationship: From being fed to receiving affection, infants need to learn to trust that their Debater parents can provide for them. If their basic needs are not met, it can lead to a sense of mistrust in all their subsequent relationships.

When parents are inconsistent in providing for their children, their infants may have difficulty creating positive, trusting attachments. On the other hand, attentive and affectionate parents, especially those who engage in consistent physical contact, such as snuggling or baby wearing, encourage trusting, hopeful relationships that help their children to build positive attachments with others.

Balanced Parenting During Infancy

Intrigued and Inspired

The awe and beauty of bringing new life into the world aren't lost on Debaters, and the birth of their own children is often profoundly interesting to this generally intellectual type. Much like their desire to debate the mysteries of the cosmos and other such lofty concepts, these parents look upon their infants as enigmas wrapped inside onesies. With limitless potential and possibilities, they're thrilling and inspirational little humans.

Intrigued and inspired, Debaters who take the opportunity to appreciate this stage for the fresh start that it is are likely to be rewarded. Figuring out what makes their babies tick is like a scientific endeavor for parents with this personality type. They gather information and conduct experiments as they observe their infants during this stage of rapid growth and development. Involved Debaters find that they have front-row seats to one of the most fascinating case studies: the transformation of a gurgling, cooing, helpless baby into a walking, talking, functioning person.

The "Anti-Helicopter" Parent

Many parents find themselves hovering over their newborns, fretting over every gurgle, cough, and cry, but Debaters can be remarkably relaxed when it comes to parenting. This isn't due to a lack of concern:

Confident Debaters who have prepared for their parental roles see no rational reason to get worked up over every little thing. Taking care of their babies to the best of their abilities is their priority; worrying about everything that could go wrong only gets in the way of that goal.

Avoiding excessive worry is only one part of their laid-back approach to parenting during infancy, however. Their strong live-and-let-live mentality means that parents with this personality type, at their best, interact with their children without feeling a need to control them. During this stage, they revel in engaging with their babies through caretaking activities like feeding and bath time, as well as through play. They're less likely than others to feel as though they must attend parent-baby yoga sessions or schedule play dates for their non-verbal, not-yet-crawling infants to "properly socialize" them. Promoting their children's development is good, but Debaters are unlikely to obsess over it.

Unbalanced Parenting During Infancy

My Kid Is Smarter Than Yours!

It certainly is exciting to see a baby roll over for the first time, sit up on their own, or expertly stack their periodic table element blocks, but trying to push children to achieve milestones early usually only causes frustration. Just because an infant isn't saying their first words at the same time as another baby doesn't mean they aren't as intelligent. Development, especially at this stage, isn't a measure of parents' or newborns' intelligence. Debater parents and their infants tend to be much happier and more relaxed if their sons and daughters can grow and develop at their own pace.

Having kids who appear to be advanced or exceptionally intelligent is certainly a confidence boost for parents of all personality types. However, parents who focus on achieving milestones over building bonds (which, paradoxically, have more of an impact on children's achievement than educational activities) can be detrimental to their infants' overall development and their parent-child relationships. Babies who trust that their Debater parents will meet their needs can comfortably focus on gaining the new skills that naturally develop from their interactions with loving, attentive caregivers.

Rebalancing Parenting During Infancy

Focusing on Support Over Achievement

At this stage, Debaters should understand that developmental milestones are approximate, and they're meant for evaluation and not comparison. Children who attain certain milestones earlier aren't always "advanced," those who achieve them later aren't necessarily "delayed," and labeling children in such ways can be detrimental to their development and their self-esteem throughout their lives. The expectations that come with labels easily influence people's behavior, often in negative ways. There's absolutely nothing wrong with having high expectations of children, if parents temper expectations with understanding, acceptance, and patience.

Children of all ages, including infants, need unconditional love and acceptance from their parents. Debater parents should turn their attention away from achievement and toward support of their infants' growth at their own pace. At this stage, support consists of meeting their sons and daughters where they are developmentally and providing regular and consistent encouragement. Infants who receive this type of unconditional love and support learn to trust their parents, and they are likely to have greater success developing healthy, trusting relationships with others in the future as well.

The following are ways Debaters can organically encourage their infants while still accepting their current limitations. The activities should be done with as much physical contact as possible: for example, holding their children while reading or playing with interactive toys rather than just setting them down to play on their own:

- Use items that encourage interaction (with the toy *and* the parent) rather than just providing passive entertainment. Try blocks, rattles, puzzles, and age-appropriate musical instruments (like a plastic toy drum.)
- Talk to infants frequently – explain how food is being prepared, talk about the weather outside, or describe what is happening with a toy they're playing with. Conversations, whether infants understand what is being said or not, promote language development and create a special bond between parents and children by increasing engagement.

- Read to babies at every opportunity. It's one of the easiest and most meaningful ways to interact, while also encouraging language development and promoting visual stimulation.

Encouragement and acceptance aren't mutually exclusive – it's possible to promote their infants' growth while still accepting (completely normal) limitations. However, in such instances where parents should be concerned about their children's development (or lack thereof), they should have conversations with their family physicians or pediatricians to identify issues and develop plans to address them.

Testing Boundaries (1½–3 Years)

Once they're mobile, young children become very interested in exploring their environments with their senses. Crawling, walking, grabbing items, putting things in their mouths, and communicating verbally are just a few of the ways toddlers learn about the world around them.

During this stage, Debater parents must provide a safe harbor for their children while still allowing them to experience and explore their surroundings. Toddlers who can test boundaries while still receiving parental support and encouragement develop a sense of autonomy. Children who are overly restricted, criticized, or made to feel guilty for their desire to test boundaries ultimately will experience a sense of shame and may suffer from feelings of incompetence or low self-worth. Such feelings can last throughout their lives and may ultimately jeopardize their ability to achieve goals and develop positive character traits such as decisiveness, reliability, and confidence.

Balanced Parenting During the Toddler Stage

Eagerly Encouraging Learning

Learning is a priority for Debaters, so they're always encouraging their children to engage in educational activities. The exploration stage is an exciting one for parents and children alike, as they witness meaningful milestones such as talking, walking, and learning how to use and manipulate toys, tools, and utensils. Debater parents provide their daughters and sons with plenty of stimulation and opportunities for exploration.

From reading science-fiction bedtime stories to outfitting the nursery with a planetarium night light, conscientious Debaters are likely to incorporate learning into everything they do with their children. Such experiences not only increase their toddlers' knowledge, they create deeper parent-child bonds. Additionally, the more positive experiences that kids have learning with their parents, the more likely they are to seek out educational experiences in the future. Debaters who invest their time encouraging growth and learning with their toddlers are laying the foundation for them to feel safe and confident in their educational (and life) endeavors.

Curious and Questioning

Debaters are one of the most curious personality types – they're just as interested in exploring and questioning the world around them as their children are. These parents have no problem understanding their kids' desire to test boundaries. This shared eagerness to explore can provide incredible opportunities for bonding both intellectually and emotionally.

Many parents feel frustrated by the endless questions and outspoken opinions of toddlers. Less so for Debaters, who likely feel a tinge of pride when their children show their desire to learn more. Although they certainly expect their sons and daughters to respect their authority, Debaters are more than willing to entertain questions or challenges if they deem them legitimate. And toddlers who believe that their parents can always provide them with a safe harbor from which to question and explore are more likely to develop a healthy sense of autonomy – something Debater parents proudly encourage and support.

Unbalanced Parenting During the Toddler Stage

Impatient with Irrationality

Debaters understand that toddlers have limited cognitive abilities because of their developmental stage, but that doesn't always prevent them from becoming impatient with the toddler brand of "reasoning." Irrational arguments are a pet peeve for people with this personality type, and toddlers are masters of that form. Some personality types

can overlook the inanity of children at this age, but Debater parents may be more susceptible to frustration, which can quickly devolve to criticism or even anger, guaranteeing that the situation will escalate rather than improve.

Toddlers are notorious for lying and arguing about ridiculous things. Three-year-olds may yell at their parents, insisting they aren't pouring their cereal on the floor even as they're in the process of doing just that. Even though this may be a sincere act of exploration ("Maybe the dog is hungry – I'll feed him some of my cereal!"), Debaters may see it as frustratingly illogical or irrational. If they choose to deal with misbehavior in a critical way rather than using it as an educational opportunity ("Time to learn how to use a broom!"), their children are likely to become frustrated, withdrawn, resentful, and even more likely to misbehave.

Rebalancing Parenting During the Toddler Stage

Consider the Context

To be fair, rarely, if ever, do toddlers misbehave out of malice or conscious disrespect for their parents. At this stage, arguments and lies are generally results of their desire to be understood, a failure to realize the significance of their actions, or simply an effort to avoid getting in trouble. With their limited ability to communicate their thoughts and feelings, children at this age act out in ways that defy logic. If Debaters fail to see such behavior in the context of development and let their irritation get the best of them, they may resort to punishment over more constructive and educational disciplinary practices.

Improving their patience is key for Debaters who are looking to address their toddlers' behavior in positive and productive ways – but this is certainly easier said than done. Patience improves when parents can adapt to their children's evolving needs, abilities, and, yes, even their ever-changing attitudes. Developing a mindful presence can help frustrated Debaters to refrain from reacting negatively any time their kids' behavior becomes challenging.

The following activity can help Debater parents to press "pause" and reassess a situation before a downward spiral begins:

- Stop and breathe. Whatever is taking place – whether a toddler temper tantrum or a potty-training setback – take a step back from the situation (when safe and appropriate) and take five deep breaths.
- Take a moment to remember that children at this stage aren't behaving negatively out of spite or as a personal attack.
- Consider things from their point of view. Perhaps they're sleepy, hungry, overwhelmed, misunderstood, or just plain frustrated themselves.
- Think about what can be done to turn the situation into a "win" for everyone. Maybe Junior could use a nap, which would also give parents some quiet time. Perhaps they could have a nice snack together.

The goal of this activity is to remain present and focus on the best outcome for both parties involved while keeping toddlers' intellectual, emotional, and behavioral capabilities in mind. Debaters understand what it feels like to be misunderstood. Learning to put their children's behavior in context provides the understanding needed by themselves and their children.

Thirst for Knowledge (3–5 Years)

The preschool years, from approximately 3–5 years of age, are a prime time for brain development, and children at this stage accumulate knowledge at an extraordinary rate. They absorb information like sponges through constant activity and a seemingly infinite stream of disparate questions. Learning at this stage takes place through play, especially the unstructured and imaginary kind, as well as lots of social interaction with family and peers. Creativity is also exercised extensively through make-believe games and stories.

Preschoolers who lack opportunities to practice initiating activities and get annoyed reactions to their constant questions or childish make-believe games may feel guilty, frustrated, and powerless. Consequently, they

may suffer from poor self-control or a lack of initiative. Debater parents who wish to navigate this stage successfully must give their daughters and sons the opportunity to make some of their own decisions, initiate activities, ask questions, receive answers, and lead others in exploratory play. Preschoolers who are encouraged to take initiative are likely to be more confident in their actions – and much more likely to independently pursue their own goals in the future as well.

Balanced Parenting During the Preschool Years

Competent Mentors

Debaters are known as enthusiastic, quick-witted, confident, and original individuals who excel at solving problems, and they often model such behaviors for their children. They're likely to encourage their kids to initiate and engage in imaginative play and practice creative problem-solving through activities like board games and puzzles. As stated in the previous section (and it's very important, so it bears repeating), Debater parents encourage learning and often gladly answer their children's incessant streams of questions. In fact, they take great pleasure from explaining concepts, especially complicated ones, and they enjoy their role as informers.

Although educational activities are important to Debater parents, they value many topics. They aim to instill into their children curiosity, independent thinking, and an ability to look at the world objectively – qualities that are just as important as any set of skills. With the same energy they use for brainstorming points and counterpoints for their next conversation, Debaters can encourage their preschoolers to see learning opportunities everywhere, to value chances to experience or create something.

A simple walk around the neighborhood, for instance, can be an impromptu lesson on the basic physics behind a falling acorn and the geological make-up of interesting rocks. Trips to the grocery store are perfect opportunities to practice counting money and making healthy food choices. Debaters enjoy prompting their preschoolers to question and consider everything – for better or worse! – and they instill a deep curiosity and a love of learning from a very early age.

Independence as Empowerment

Debaters don't care what anybody thinks of them, a perspective they encourage in their children as well. For them, dependency is discouraged; Debater parents work to pass on the skills their sons and daughters need to be independent, confident individuals. Knowledge is power – which is exactly what Debaters want their children to have and project. The more they can teach their kids, whether facts or age-appropriate skills, the more they feel they've prepared them to succeed.

In the preschool stage, they encourage their little ones to develop their own critical thinking skills. For example, these parents might expect their kids to use their problem-solving skills to deal with any difficult children they encounter. They're unlikely to pander to their preschoolers' desire for them to interject themselves and solve any issues they may encounter. Instead, Debaters are likely to work with them to figure out age-appropriate solutions to their problems.

Unbalanced Parenting During the Preschool Years

Believing Tact and Compassion Are Unnecessary

Some of the behaviors Debaters model aren't always positive or productive. Objectivity is more important to them than empathy, so some Debaters may find it unnecessary to teach their children how to communicate with compassion or tact. Parents with this personality type are often more interested in seeing their kids pursue ambitious goals than in helping them to develop positive relationships with others. Grappling with life's mysteries, which at this stage may entail learning to use scissors and mastering the ABCs, may take precedence over social niceties.

In fact, social niceties may not even register on the radar of less-than-sensitive Debaters. Biting criticism is often a hallmark of this personality type, especially during "passionate discussions" – typically arguments in all but name. When frustrated or annoyed by their little ones' antics, Debaters can be especially cruel in their commentary. Negative criticism can be damaging to children at this stage, who are especially sensitive to it. Frequent, harsh confrontations may provoke feelings of guilt that are difficult to overcome. Calling their questions "dumb"

or their ideas or concerns "illogical" can be crushing to preschoolers during this phase. Without the context or clarification to understand such comments, children can feel unimportant or inconvenient to their parents, which sets them up for future resentment.

Rebalancing Parenting During the Preschool Years

Increasing Compassion and Understanding

For Debater parents to promote their children's initiative and self-confidence, as well as to teach them healthy social skills, they need to practice being compassionate and understanding themselves. Being critical is especially damaging to children who, at this stage, are just beginning to develop confidence in their abilities and the initiative necessary to pursue further learning of their own accord.

To prevent the guilt and withdrawal that may evolve when kids constantly feel as though they're wrong or unimportant, Debater parents need to reassess how they're communicating with their preschoolers. Are they modeling compassionate communication? Are they patient during stressful conversations, or do they quickly become critical? Do they promote empathetic behavior, such as concern when someone is sad, angry, or hurt? Or do they tend to avoid other people when they're expressing emotions? If Debaters find that they aren't communicating in a way that models compassion or understanding, they can try the following activity:

- Identify a situation that triggers an angry or critical response – perhaps your preschooler throwing toys instead of picking them up.
- Consider the "default," normal response. Yelling? Threatening to take away (or throw away) toys that aren't picked up? Possibly sending the child to time-out? Maybe telling the preschooler they're lazy, disrespectful, or naughty?
- Consider – maybe through discussion with a friend or partner – why the situation elicits an angry or critical response. Is it a question of respect? Do you fear that your child doesn't like you (because otherwise they would surely listen)? Do you worry that the child is just plain "bad?"

- Instead of taking the preschooler's behavior personally, look for ways to respond to the situation with understanding. They may not want to pick up their toys because they're having too much fun, or they may be tired.
- Respond in a way that addresses the behavior with compassion rather than frustration, such as, "I know you're tired, but we need to pick up the toys before you lie down. Here, let me help you." Or, "I know that you're having fun, but we must go to the grocery store, so we need to pick the toys up now. Don't worry, you can play with them again when we get home!"

Understanding is the root of compassion, so when Debater parents take the time to figure out how their perception might differ from their preschoolers' intention, they gain opportunities to connect with their children in intentional, meaningful ways.

Creating Competence (5–12 Years)

The early school years are an important period of skill development for young children. Not only are they still constantly absorbing new information, but they're also working on becoming proficient in increasingly complex areas, from relationships to mathematics to athletics. Children who are both challenged and supported flourish in their abilities and their self-confidence.

If they don't receive consistent support, kids at this stage can begin to feel inferior to their peers and may be less likely to develop long-term goals or work toward achieving them. On the other hand, children at this stage who aren't sufficiently challenged can begin to feel overly confident in themselves and their abilities, perhaps eventually lacking modesty and compassion toward others.

Balanced Parenting in the School-Age Years

Encouraging Deep Learning

Challenging others is one of Debaters' greatest strengths. They have no trouble challenging their daughters and sons to improve themselves

as well, helping them set and achieve increasingly ambitious goals – though those goals may not always take expected forms. Taking bold, positive risks is of utmost importance to Debaters, and they take every opportunity to promote their children's desire to increase their knowledge and skills. Are their kids passionate about dinosaurs? Debater parents are likely to provide books, educational videos, and museum trips galore.

Not ones to settle for merely "learning about something," Debater parents place a great deal of importance on actively exploring and deeply understanding their children's passions. The enthusiasm they have for ideas and passion projects often inspires their kids to learn more about whatever they pursue, especially in areas related to their intellectual development. Although they prize intelligence, Debaters are no strangers to hard work, and they encourage children of all levels and abilities to achieve their personal best.

Setting Up for Success

Children at this stage are learning to set and achieve goals, and Debater parents can be excellent models of the brainstorming ability and determination needed to reach goals. School-aged kids face increasing expectations in terms of attaining skills and knowledge, and they benefit from parents who can teach them how to strategically meet expectations. Debaters find great joy in helping their children to brainstorm plans and figure out what they must do to achieve their goals – academically, socially, and personally.

Developing long-term goals is a challenge for children who are only just learning to effectively engage in future planning. The skill becomes increasingly necessary during the school-age years, and Debater parents can draw on their own goal-setting experiences to help their children successfully navigate this stage. They can use their skills to help their young scholars approach projects ("OK, you want to make a solar-powered toilet for the science fair? Let's figure out what you need so that you can make the best toilet possible.")

Unbalanced Parenting in the School-Age Years

Excessive Ambition

Ambition is an impressive trait, but when it becomes a cornerstone of their identity, Debaters may find themselves unintentionally eroding their children's confidence with criticism. Kids at this stage are just being introduced to topics, not taking a deep dive into theoretical implications or foundational underpinnings. Expecting their children to understand the collegiate-level algebraic theories behind their elementary-level math homework is unrealistic. This doesn't apply only to intellectual pursuits; cognitive development, which includes intellectual and psychological components, is still in the beginning stages, making logical understanding difficult (if not impossible.)

An excessively ambitious approach that fails to account for children's feelings is unlikely to go over well with them at this stage. School-aged children who are sensitive are even more likely to react with behavioral outbursts or refusal to engage with others out of fear of rejection. Debaters who are unable or unwilling to connect with their children on an emotional level because they fail to see the logic in that approach can have difficulty promoting the confidence their sons and daughters need to become self-assured, competent adults.

Rebalancing Parenting in the School-Age Years

Listen Up

It's important for Debater parents to balance their ambition with compassion and understanding. Peers and teachers exert increasing influence on school-age children, but parents still have the lead role in helping their sons and daughters develop their skills, goals, and, ultimately, self-esteem. Debaters who push their children too hard need to dial down criticism and focus on empathizing with them. As forward-thinking as they are, and as successful as they hope their children may be, Debater parents must learn to temper their motivations with something more sensitive.

Active listening is one of the most effective ways to practice compassion with children. The following steps can help Debater parents to develop

active listening skills to communicate with their children in more empathetic and effective ways:

- Take time to listen to your child's concerns, questions, and frustrations without focusing exclusively on how to solve their problems. It helps to use a specific non-question statement that indicates they've been heard, such as, "That sounds like a great idea," or "That sounds really frustrating."
- Once you have taken time to improve understanding of the situation, focus on helping the child to find solutions (if necessary) by asking questions, such as, "What do you think might help?"
- Practice non-judgment when actively listening. Resist the temptation to form or offer any opinions; just listen.
- Be aware of body language. Debaters tend to use dominant or aggressive posturing in conversation. Instead, coming down to your child's eye level can help. If the child is standing, crouch to meet them. If the child is sitting, sit as well. These acts lend a sense of equality to the conversation, helping children to feel more confident in voicing their thoughts.

In most circumstances, more than well-meaning advice and opinions, kids just need someone to listen – a helpful skill for Debaters to learn for their communications with children and adults alike. Debater parents who support their sons and daughters with positive communication and sincere interest in what they have to say can get to know their children better and bolster their confidence. Confidence that their parents love them, and at least try to understand them, gives them the support they need to take on the world.

Find Thyself (12–18 Years)

Adolescence is the transition from childhood to adulthood, when children focus on developing their own distinct identities. This transitional period centers around their realization of what their roles are in their relationships with themselves, others, and society in general. To determine their roles, adolescents at this point begin the all-important process of identifying their personal values and beliefs.

At this stage, educational and future career goals form and relationships develop based on values and beliefs – making this a pivotal, foundational stage for the rest of their lives. Teens who navigate this stage successfully move from dependency on their parents for direction and support to an interdependence that allows them to rely on their own values for guidance while maintaining respectful, loving relationships with others.

Balanced Parenting During Adolescence

Encouraging Exploration

As adaptable, energetic individuals, Debaters are naturally prone to exploration and investigation. No topic is off limits, and no question is too big or obscure to be thoroughly discussed (and possibly dissected). These qualities take on even greater significance for Debater parents during their children's adolescent years, when conversations become more complex and have fewer clear-cut answers. Their fearless approach to addressing even the touchiest of topics can help to instill confidence in their teenage sons and daughters, who may be overwhelmed by the mature issues they're beginning to face.

Debaters' passion for exploration is especially useful for encouraging their kids to take the initiative in their personal growth and education. Parents with this personality type who model personal vision and a passion for learning new skills teach their teens *how* to learn – not just *what* they should learn. Learning a new skill or exploring a new topic takes curiosity and determination, both of which motivated Debaters have copious amounts. Their natural desire to learn and improve is palpable, and their kids witness such behavior on a regular basis. They encourage their children to explore any interests they may have, regardless of how "practical" they may be, which can be just the confidence boost adolescents need to pursue their passions.

Promoting Development of Personal Objectives

During this stage of identity development, adolescents need their parents' support and understanding more than ever. One of the most important aspects of personal growth for Debaters is their development of personal objectives, which are used to support various

aspects of their identities. Those who remain open to others' individual perspectives and needs encourage their children to develop their own unique codes of conduct that resonate with them and aren't purely influenced by external factors. If their teens' objectives require hard work and the pursuit of a passion, Debater parents let them create their own plans to meet their personal needs and desires.

Debaters can encourage their children to develop a code of conduct by promoting and modeling such positive values as objectivity, creative thinking, independence, and lifelong learning, while providing a supportive environment. Parents who demonstrate an involved but unimposing interest when assisting with their children's personal development also empower their teens to discover their own distinct identities and express themselves confidently.

Unbalanced Parenting During Adolescence

Permission to Do... Whatever

The more independent their children become, the more likely Debaters are to relinquish previously enforced control or structure. Permissiveness that goes too far – by failing to set or enforce any boundaries, even actively encouraging "bold" behaviors – can result in adolescents who engage in unsafe behaviors: drinking, having unprotected sex, driving recklessly, experimenting with drugs, etc. Though they may seem mature, teens are cognitively incapable of fully understanding the potential consequences of their behavior. It's up to parents to help them, or they risk seeing their kids make decisions that cannot be reversed.

Debaters, who themselves despise feeling controlled by others, may view any rules or guidelines that interfere with free will be too detrimental to autonomy. There's a significant difference, however, between being *authoritative* as a parent – being trustworthy, reliable, and considerate – and being *authoritarian* – focusing on strict obedience to authority regardless of personal circumstance.

Rebalancing Parenting During Adolescence

Promoting Self-Discipline

Understanding is crucial as Debater parents navigate their adolescent children's changing needs and growing independence. This stage requires a constant rebalancing of responsibility and expectations as teens become more capable, responsible, and mature. It can be difficult for Debaters to enforce the boundaries their adolescent children need at a stage when they seem so capable. These parents pride themselves on their own autonomy and want to help their children achieve the same level of independence as soon as possible. But too much freedom at this stage can lead to tragedy, so their parents must help them understand that their choices come with consequences.

Debater parents who wish to encourage their children's personal growth and independence while still maintaining the structure and boundaries necessary at this stage should focus on promoting self-discipline. Adolescents who work to actively develop self-discipline – persevering through life's trials and delaying gratification to set themselves up for future success – are much more likely to be healthy, independent, and accomplished adults. Authoritative parenting helps children practice self-discipline, teaching them to regulate themselves rather than rely on parents for correction. One way to foster self-discipline is to teach adolescents how to control their emotions (an especially difficult task at this stage) using the "ABCDE" method:

- A: Identify an **a**ctivating event (for example, failing their driver's license test).
- B: Determine the irrational **b**eliefs that resulted from that event (in this example, believing that the test was impossible or that they were "too stupid" to pass it).
- C: Consider the emotional **c**onsequences of those beliefs. (Anger, frustration, and sadness may result in teens yelling at their parents over an issue that's relatively minor, even though it seems major at the time.)
- D: **D**ispute or challenge the irrational beliefs. (Discuss the irrational belief that the test was impossible or that they're too stupid to pass, then determine whether the issue was more likely caused by a lack of study and practice, leading to test anxiety or knowledge gaps.)

- E: Replace irrational beliefs with new, effective beliefs that result in positive behaviors. (Studying and practicing before retaking the driver's license test can increase knowledge and improve confidence, hopefully preventing test anxiety and resulting in a passing score.)

Debaters can help their adolescent children walk through the ABCDE process a few times before they're comfortable practicing it on their own. The idea behind the activity is that teens can learn how to handle their emotions and, in turn, gain the foundational skills that support self-discipline. Debater parents who practice those skills with their kids help them develop the tools they need to function most effectively on their own.

Conclusion

Parenting is one of the most challenging experiences that anyone can face, regardless of their personality type. Debaters have their own unique strengths that they can leverage – curiosity, originality, enthusiasm, and quick-wittedness – as well as weaknesses that they need to understand and balance to build positive, proactive relationships with their children. There's tremendous potential for personal development when one becomes a parent, and Debaters can gain a much deeper understanding of themselves and others if they use the opportunity to do so.

The advice provided in this chapter is based on general growth stages for children and basic strengths and weaknesses that many Debaters share. All children are different, and parents are the best judge of what their kids need. The information above should be used in a way that works best for each family without adding additional stress, frustration, or burden. For special situations, such as behavioral or medical issues, it's best to consult with professional pediatricians or pediatric psychologists to come up with plans that work best for everyone involved.

Final Words

Exploring Others

Relationships with others, be they romantic, friendly, or familial, can be quite an adventure. The thoughts, experiences, and history that people can share together can provide deep levels of fulfillment like nothing else. As Extraverts, Debaters cannot help but seek the potential rewards that they can reap with others in various forms. Everything from love to intellectual validation is essential to Debaters' happiness, on some level, and they find these things in the company of others. But shared rewards are only part of the adventure that awaits in social relationships.

People themselves are like little universes, containing ideas, biases, and unexpected aspects both delightful and odd. Every relationship is an opportunity for Debaters not just to create shared rewards with someone but also to explore the unique internal reality of each person. It's not always easy for Debaters to be receptive observers and restrain their own energy, but a passive mode of appreciative examination is yet another way that these personality types can enjoy their relationships. That might mean exploring a romantic partner's lifestyle preferences, taking a lengthy tour of a friend's observations on life, or seeing the world through a child's unfettered imagination, all without trying to influence those other personal realities. Debaters love to understand things by rationally deconstructing them, and there's great value in occasionally playing the role of a neutral observer, simply drinking in what exists in other people's minds, perceptions, and experiences.

For one thing, a deep dive into another person's thoughts and feelings helps Debaters forge better connections with them. That's a great way to build a relationship – and for Debaters to assess who they want to connect with in the first place. And in the case of close, familiar people, occasionally showing such receptiveness can send a powerful message of appreciation. Those close to Debaters are undoubtedly used to their expressive manner, and when those people suddenly find themselves center stage with a cheerful audience, it can be quite flattering. Exciting mutual interactions will always form the heart of Debaters' most fulfilling relationships, but experiencing other people for who and what they are can add a deeper dimension to shared experiences – and relationships themselves.

Remembering Social Goals

In darker moments, Debaters may find other people to be tedious at best, as if they're obstacles to be avoided – or, if not avoidable, overcome. Alternately, social relationships may sometimes make people with this personality type feel like proverbial bulls in porcelain-filled shops, accidentally doing damage to those with more fragile sensibilities. As much as Debaters may sometimes enjoy provoking others, doing so accidentally can become frustrating. But given the social nature of life and the degree of joyful excitement that Debaters find in the world around them, these momentary issues need not stand in the way of lifelong social goals, whatever they may be.

As Debaters move forward in life, they come to understand what works (and what they want) and what doesn't through a process of trial and error, learning from their environment and the responses that their actions produce. So it is with relationships as well: these flexible and energetic people are rarely prone to giving up, even in the midst of frustration or confusion. It's important for Debaters to hold on to their goals in life, including the ones that involve other people. And, perhaps, it's also important to take a moment now and then to reevaluate what those goals are and how they may best be achieved. In the many areas where Debaters benefit from – and desire – the involvement of others, it's helpful for them to keep their ultimate objectives in mind as day-to-day events unfold.

Whether it's in love, friendship, or the unique bonds of family, there almost always exists a deeper purpose that's more important than any of the incidental challenges that may occur along the way. Paying attention to their long-term social goals helps grant Debaters the perspective that they need to grow and master any relationship difficulties that they may face. Relationships are meant to be mutual adventures of enjoyment and personal meaning, and it's important that Debaters remind themselves of what that looks like in daily life. That way, they can make sure that their social goals – and all the steps leading to them – are truly part of a fulfilling life.

So... What's Next?

You've reached the end of this book, but fear not – we've created many more resources for you. Here are a few that might capture your interest:

- Want to analyze and improve your relationships with your romantic partner, friends, or children? Explore our Relationships Specialized Tests.
- Looking to set a foundation for learning and developing as a person? Check out the *Debater Guide to Personal Growth*.
- Feeling adrift when it comes to your academic path or your career? Our *Debater Guide to Careers* may be just what you need.

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